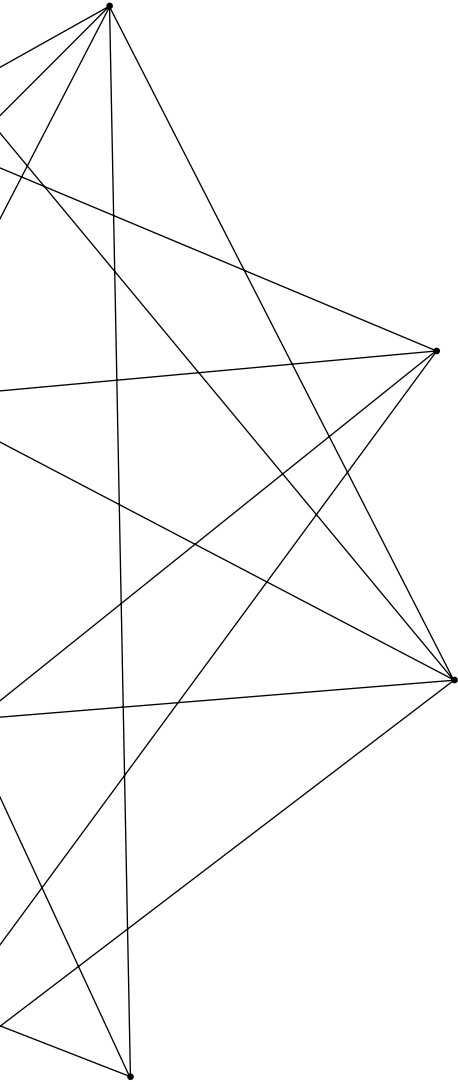
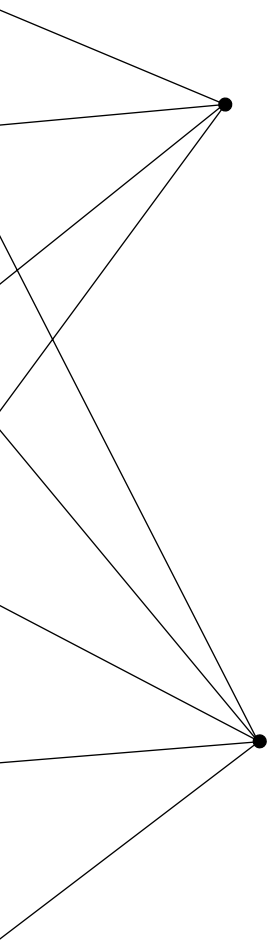




FORMS



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Whole, Rhythm, Hierarchy, Network

CAROLINE LEVINE

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Summary: "*Forms* offers a powerful new answer to one of the most pressing problems facing literary, critical, and cultural studies today—how to connect form to political, social, and historical context. Caroline Levine argues that forms organize not only works of art but also political life—and our attempts to know both art and politics. Inescapable and frequently troubling, forms shape every aspect of our experience. But forms don't impose their order in any simple way. Multiple shapes, patterns, and arrangements, overlapping and colliding, generate complex and unpredictable social landscapes that challenge and unsettle conventional analytic models in literary and cultural studies. Borrowing the concept of "affordances" from design theory, this book investigates the specific ways that four major forms—wholes, rhythms, hierarchies, and networks—have structured culture, politics, and scholarly knowledge across periods, and it proposes exciting new ways of linking formalism to historicism and literature to politics. Levine rereads both formalist and antiformalist theorists, including Cleanth Brooks, Michel Foucault, Jacques Rancière, Mary Poovey, and Judith Butler, and she offers engaging accounts of a wide range of objects, from medieval convents and modern theme parks to Sophocles's *Antigone* and the television series *The Wire*. The result is a radically new way of thinking about form for the next generation and essential reading for scholars and students across the humanities who must wrestle with the problem of form and context"— Provided by publisher.

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FOR JON

P R E F A C E

My father was a liberal humanist and a historian of ideas. He often read literary writers: he wrote on Pope and Swift. He believed that scholars should strive to understand the intentions of authors as they responded to contemporary concerns and debates. To our mutual dismay, I didn't find this approach particularly exciting. I wanted to track subtle arrangements of words and images interwoven through literary texts. When I first went to college and fell in love with poststructuralist ways of reading, my father was amused and skeptical. He would challenge me to defend "ahistorical" literary studies in debates that went on for hours. I would argue that patterns of language came before us, preceding and creating subjects; he would insist that human agency and intention were primary, shaping any utterance we make. The debates themselves were pleasurable, but he never convinced me—or I him. I wish Joseph M. Levine were alive to read this book. He would cheerfully disagree with every argument in it.

It was something of an irony for me when literary studies took a historical turn. By the time I'd graduated from college in the early 1990s, historicism was clearly displacing deconstruction as the dominant model for the field. This felt like a narrowing of the intellectual world to me, a stifling. Deconstruction had encouraged a kind of intellectual pyrotechnics; my teachers had performed readings so dazzling that a physical thrill would run through me. Now we were being asked to situate literary objects in thickly described, local contexts, with an attention to Parliamentary papers and conduct manuals. I found it dreary. And yet, the ethical arguments that the New Historicists were making had power. Deconstructive approaches might be exciting, but they were increasingly called self-indulgent; historicism might feel laborious, but it was about power and injustice—serious business. Difficult new disciplinary questions took shape for me. If conduct books contributed as much as poems to a given culture, then why wouldn't I become a historian like my father? And if social justice should be my goal, then could I justify a lifetime of studying literature?

Feeling ambivalent about literary studies, I went off to Birkbeck College, part of the University of London, to think and read for a few years, but prob-

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ably not, I thought at the time, to pursue an academic career. At Birkbeck, every scholar was a Marxist of one variety or another. All of my teachers insisted on historical methods with a political urgency that was new to me—and compelling.

The traditional Marxist attentiveness to long processes of change was especially helpful. When I expanded my attention beyond immediate local contexts, I grasped the massive and manifold disruptions that profound economic shifts had brought: the prolonged industrial revolution that moved huge numbers of people out of rural areas and into crowded cities, fundamentally reshaping social relationships and rapidly accelerating environmental devastation; the competition among European nations for new markets that uprooted and impoverished whole peoples, sometimes eradicating their languages and recasting their values as backward in a dominant story of European progress, a story that I now saw had shaped my father's work and my own childhood values. I understood for the first time how claims to artistic universality and transcendence had been used over and over as political bludgeons and how cultural objects had been crucial participants in the making and remaking of the political world. There was no way for me to pass this off as uninteresting or irrelevant.

Back in the United States, fitted out with a Birkbeck PhD and a new academic job, I realized with embarrassment that my eccentric education had somehow allowed me to skip over any serious reading of Michel Foucault. When I finally read *Discipline and Punish*, it came as a stunning revelation. It remains my single favorite work of theory. Foucault prompted in me an unsettling series of questions about revolutionary politics. Radical political movements had shown themselves capable of squelching the concerns of women, men of color, and queers, as Foucault himself saw first-hand in the French Communist Party of the 1950s. He came to argue that when revolutionaries imagined newly just distributions, they were also envisioning new social orders, sets of standards to govern relations among bodies, ideas, and resources. Even the most radical new arrangements could entail their own painful, oppressive normalizations and exclusions. "Every power relation is not bad in itself," Foucault said in an interview, "but it is a fact that always involves danger."¹ *Discipline and Punish* showed how even seemingly ordinary arrangements of space and time permitted certain circulations of power, while foreclosing others. It was Foucault, then, who suggested to me for the first time that organizations and arrangements were the main means by which power worked: politics was a matter of imposing order on the world.

It never occurred to me not to call these ordering principles *forms*. I, who had always been drawn to patterns and structures in and across texts, imme-

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diately grasped social experience in the same terms, using what seemed to me the same habits of thought, the same methods. I wrote a book about a temporal pattern that organized both narrative suspense and the scientific method in the Victorian period, and followed this with a book about structural tensions between avant-garde artists and democratic states. I understood all of these as forms.

It took me a long while to realize that this use of the term was not intuitive to other literary critics, who typically equated form with genre, or saw form as the exclusive domain of aesthetics. Form, for many literary readers, was precisely that which *distinguished* art objects from ordinary life. More and more this seemed to me arbitrary and misleading; if we were interested in containers and enclosures, then why not analyze prison cells or national boundaries, and if we wanted to understand patternings of time, then why not focus on factory routines? All of these were designed arrangements—deliberately crafted to impose order—just like art objects. Even those exciting critics who were challenging dominant practices of historicism with a renewed attention to form—critics like Heather Dubrow, Franco Moretti, Garrett Stewart, Herbert Tucker, Susan Wolfson, and Alex Woloch—were reading aesthetic forms as responses to given social realities. I wanted to know, instead, how both aesthetic *and* social forms acted in the world, and how they interacted and overlapped with each other. Literary critics, who excelled at spotting the difficult overlayings of multiple structures, who understood precisely how complex forms could be, seemed to be missing an opportunity to read social structures—politics—in the same alert, insightful ways.

As I read further about politics and form, I started to notice that literary and cultural studies scholars often assumed that aesthetic forms were tremendously complex, while political forms were comparatively simple. Powerful, even all-encompassing, but simple in themselves. And this, I came to believe, was not altogether wrong. Racism, for example, operates most often as a stark binary, a blunt political instrument rather than a complex formation in itself. But what literary formalists know well is that any simple order gets complicated fast once we start attending to the dense intertwining and overlapping of multiple forms. The best close readers are always attentive to many different forms at different scales operating at once. I began to track the ways that political forms *try* to contain and control us, while often in fact overlapping and colliding with other forms, and sometimes getting in one another's way.

This attention to traveling, colliding forms then brought me full circle, to a critique of the historicism that has become the daily fare of literary

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studies. From the beginning, the emphasis on local contexts has troubled me. My teachers, colleagues, and interlocutors over the years have insisted that a historical perspective yields irreducible particularity, sheer *difference*, and that it is a grave ethical error to draw too close a likeness between past and present. Presentism, the name for this error, is a charge so serious in literary and cultural studies that it has brought many a conversation to an end. And yet, I have always thought, none of our research *matters* unless it is generalizable, unless we can learn something from it that has implications beyond its own time. Even if the most important lesson we learn is the specificity of each historical moment, that too is a general conclusion—one, ironically, that generalizes specificity itself.

But I have never been convinced that the main value of historicism, even for historicists, lies in the distinctiveness of past periods. The most historically minded scholars choose to study gender norms in ancient Rome or eighteenth-century global commodity routes precisely because comparable arrangements of power operate now: because gender and commodity forms still organize us, carrying their pain and injustice with them; because distributions of authority and goods continue to restrict life and labor; and because we can reflect on the contingency of our own ordering principles when we know that they have at other times been organized otherwise. The past shows us what is possible—and we return, again and again, to its arrangements: the ordering of bodies and spaces, hierarchies and narratives, containments and exclusions. All of these have mattered to us because these configurations are the stuff of injustice, and also because structures like these travel and persist, continuing to organize our lives.

This book, like many others in the humanities, is an attempt to think about how we might make our world more just. One of the places where humans have some agency is in the orders that we ourselves impose: our spatial and temporal arrangements, our hierarchies of value and distributions of wealth—our *forms*. I am not persuaded that smashing or evading these forms has ever been the only or the most effective means to advance the cause of social justice. Arrangements and structurings are too pervasive, and some of them—like a fair redistribution of resources—too valuable, to reject out of hand. Nor am I convinced that it will ever be effective to focus all of our attention on any one form, singling it out as the cause or basis of all the others. It is by no means clear that capitalism always produces sexism, for example, or the other way around. Some forms dominate others at some moments and then falter or recede. But why? Why do gender norms organize the workplace at certain points while at others a workplace hierarchy unsettles gender norms? These questions have led me to recognize the ale-

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atory possibilities that lie in the encounters among forms. The instabilities generated by formal collisions are a major focus of the chapters that follow.

What this book proposes, first and foremost, is a method. I aim to show that paying attention to subtle and complex formal patterns allows us to rethink the historical workings of political power and the relations between politics and aesthetics. Foucault was right to focus on the shapes and arrangements that structure everyday experience. But I have come to believe that he was wrong to imagine that these forms converge in massive regimes of coordinated power. The world is much more chaotic and contingent, formally speaking, than Foucault imagined, and therefore much more interesting—and just a little bit more hopeful as well. Literary formalists have precisely the tools to grasp this formal complexity and, with them, to begin to imagine workable, progressive, thoughtful relations among forms—including containing wholes, rhythms of labor, economic, racial and sexual hierarchies, and sprawling, connective networks of capital. For those who care passionately about unjust arrangements of power, this book argues that formalism offers a promising way forward.

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The Affordances of Form

If a literary critic today set out to do a formalist reading of Charlotte Brontë's *Jane Eyre*, she would know just where to begin: with literary techniques both large and small, including the marriage plot, first-person narration, description, free indirect speech, suspense, metaphor, and syntax. Thanks to rich recent work on the history of the book, she might also consider the novel's material shape—its size, binding, volume breaks, margins, and typeface. But unlike formalists of a couple of generations before, she would be unlikely to rest content with an analysis of these forms alone. Traditional formalist analysis—close reading—meant interpreting all of the formal techniques of a text as contributing to an overarching artistic whole. A contemporary critic, informed by several decades of historical approaches, would want instead to take stock of the social and political conditions that surrounded the work's production, and she would work to connect the novel's forms to its social world. She would seek to show how literary techniques reinforced or undermined specific institutions and political relationships, such as imperial power, global capital, or racism. Along the way, our critic would most likely keep her formalism and her historicism analytically separate, drawing from close reading methods to understand the literary forms, while using historical research methods to analyze sociopolitical experience. These would seem to her to belong to separate realms and to call for different methods.

But would our critic be right to distinguish between the *formal* and the *social*? Consider the early scenes in *Jane Eyre*, where Brontë first introduces Lowood School. In the morning, a bell rings loudly to wake the girls. When it rings a second time, “all formed in file, two and two, and in that order descended the stairs.” On hearing a verbal command, the children move into “four semicircles, before four chairs, placed at the four tables; all held books in their hands.” When the bell rings yet again, three teachers enter and begin an hour of Bible reading before the girls march in to breakfast.

Although this new world feels overwhelming at first, Jane—quick-witted and obedient—soon achieves success. “In time I rose to be the first girl of the first class.”¹ Critics are used to reading Lowood’s disciplinary order as part of the novel’s content and context, interpreting the school experience as indispensable to Jane’s maturation, for example, or as characteristic of trends in nineteenth-century education.² But what are Lowood’s shapes and arrangements—its semicircles, timed durations, and ladders of achievement—if not themselves kinds of *form*?

This book makes a case for expanding our usual definition of form in literary studies to include patterns of sociopolitical experience like those of Lowood School. Broadening our definition of form to include social arrangements has, as we will see, immediate methodological consequences. The traditionally troubling gap between the form of the literary text and its content and context dissolves. Formalist analysis turns out to be as valuable to understanding sociopolitical institutions as it is to reading literature. Forms are at work everywhere.

One might object, of course, that it is a category mistake to use the aesthetic term *form* to describe the daily routines of a nineteenth-century school. Surely the relation between literary and social forms is just an analogy, or an identity working at too a high level of abstraction—an expansion of the word *form* so broad as to make it meaningless. But a brief look at the history of the term suggests otherwise. Over many centuries, *form* has gestured to a series of conflicting, sometimes even paradoxical meanings. Form can mean immaterial idea, as in Plato, or material shape, as in Aristotle. It can indicate essence, but it can also mean superficial trappings, such as conventions—*mere forms*. Form can be generalizing and abstract, or highly particular (as in the form of *this* thing is what makes it what it is, and if it were reorganized it would not be the same thing). Form can be cast as historical, emerging out of particular cultural and political circumstances, or it can be understood as ahistorical, transcending the specificities of history.³ In disciplinary terms, form can point us to visual art, music, and literature, but it belongs equally to philosophy, law, mathematics, military science, and crystallography. Even within literary studies, the vocabulary of formalism has always been a surprising kind of hodge-podge, put together from rhetoric, prosody, genre theory, structural anthropology, philology, linguistics, folklore, narratology, and semiotics.

Chaotic though it seems, this brief conceptual history does make two things quite clear. First, form has never belonged only to the discourse of aesthetics. It does not originate in the aesthetic, and the arts cannot lay claim to either the longest or the most far-reaching history of the term. To

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bring the disciplinary techniques of Lowood together with the literary techniques of the novel is not then an arbitrary expansion of the notion of form, nor does it draw from outside the history of formalist thinking. Instead, an attention to both aesthetic and social forms returns us to the very heterogeneity at the heart of form's conceptual history. Second, all of the historical uses of the term, despite their richness and variety, do share a common definition: "form" always indicates *an arrangement of elements—an ordering, patterning, or shaping*. Here, then, is where my own argument begins: with a definition of form that is much broader than its ordinary usage in literary studies. Form, for our purposes, will mean all shapes and configurations, all ordering principles, all patterns of repetition and difference.

Why adopt such a broad definition? The stakes, I want to suggest, are high. It is the work of form to make order. And this means that forms are the stuff of politics. Drawing on the work of Jacques Rancière, I define politics as a matter of distributions and arrangements.⁴ Political struggles include ongoing contests over the proper places for bodies, goods, and capacities. Do working-class crowds belong in the public square? Do women belong in voting booths? Does earned income belong to individuals? What land belongs to Native Americans? Sorting out what goes where, the work of political power often involves enforcing restrictive containers and boundaries—such as nation-states, bounded subjects, and domestic walls. But politics is not only about imposing order on space. It also involves organizing time: determining prison and presidential terms, naturalization periods, and the legal age for voting, military service, and sexual consent. Crucially, politics also means enforcing hierarchies of high and low, white and black, masculine and feminine, straight and queer, have and have-not. In other words, politics involves activities of ordering, patterning, and shaping. And if the political is a matter of imposing and enforcing boundaries, temporal patterns, and hierarchies on experience, then there is no politics without form.

Literary and cultural studies scholarship has focused a great deal of attention on these various political ordering principles. We have typically treated aesthetic and political arrangements as separate, and we have not generally used the language of form for both, but we have routinely drawn on social scientific accounts of "structure"; we have certainly paid attention to national boundaries and hierarchies of race and gender. And it is a commonplace practice in literary studies to read literary forms in relation to social structures. So: the field already knows a great deal about forms. But it is a knowledge that is currently scattered across schools of thought and approaches. This book proposes to bring together the field's dispersed insights into social and aesthetic forms to produce a new formalist method.

Let me start by articulating five influential ideas about how forms work. These are ideas that have guided literary and cultural studies scholars over the past few decades, but they have remained largely implicit—and disconnected from one another:

- 1 *Forms constrain.* According to a long tradition of thinkers, form is disturbing because it imposes powerful controls and containments. For some, this means that literary form itself exercises a kind of political power. In 1674, John Milton justified his use of blank verse as a reclaiming of “ancient liberty” against the “troublesome and modern bondage of rhyming.”⁵ Avant-garde poet Richard Aldington made a similar claim in 1915: “We do not insist upon ‘free-verse’ as the only method of writing poetry. We fight for it as for a principle of liberty.”⁶ In our own time, critics—especially those in the Marxist tradition—have often read literary forms as attempts to contain social clashes and contradictions.⁷
- 2 *Forms differ.* One of the great achievements of literary formalism has been the development of rich vocabularies and highly refined skills for differentiating among forms. Starting with ancient studies of prosody, theorists of poetic form around the world have debated the most precise terms for distinct patterns of rhyme and meter, and over the past hundred years theorists of narrative have developed a careful language for describing formal differences among stories, including frequency, duration, focalization, description, and suspense.⁸
- 3 *Various forms overlap and intersect.* Surprisingly, perhaps, schools of thought as profoundly different from one another as the New Criticism and intersectional analysis have developed methods for analyzing the operation of several distinct forms operating at once. The New Critics, who introduced the close reading method that dominated English departments in the middle decades of the twentieth century, deliberately traced the intricacies of overlapping literary patterns operating on different scales, as large as genre and as small as syntax. Intersectional analysis, which emerged in the social sciences and cultural studies in the late 1980s, focused our attention on how different social hierarchies overlap, sometimes powerfully reinforcing one another—how for example race and class and gender work together to keep many African-American women in a discouraging cycle of poverty.⁹
- 4 *Forms travel.* Critics have pointed to two important ways that forms move. First, a range of recent literary theorists, including Wai-Chee

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Dimock, Frances Ferguson, and Franco Moretti, have noted that certain literary forms—epic, free indirect discourse, rhythm, plot—can survive across cultures and time periods, sometimes enduring through vast distances of time and space.¹⁰ Something similar is true, though less often acknowledged, for social forms. Michel Foucault draws our attention to the daily timetable, for example, which begins by organizing life in the medieval monastery, but then gets picked up by the modern prison, factory, and school.¹¹

The second way in which forms travel, critics suggest, is by moving back and forth across aesthetic and social materials. Structuralism, a school of thought that grew influential across the social sciences in the first half of the twentieth century, made the case that human communities were organized by certain universal structures. The most important of these were binary oppositions—masculine and feminine, light and dark—which imposed a recognizable order across social and aesthetic experiences, from domestic spaces to tragic dramas. Structuralism later came under fire for assuming that these patterns were natural and therefore inexorable, but one does not have to be a structuralist to agree that binary oppositions are a pervasive and portable form, capable of imposing their arrangements on both social life and literary texts. Some critics have also worried that aesthetic forms can exert political power by imposing their artificial order on political life. Frankfurt School theorist Walter Benjamin argued against an embrace of totality in aesthetics, because it he believed it led to an embrace of totality in political communities.¹² More recent critics have often followed forms in the opposite direction: showing, for example, how a social form like a racial hierarchy moves from the political world into a novel, where it structures aesthetic experience.¹³

- 5 *Forms do political work in particular historical contexts.* In recent years, scholars interested in reviving an interest in form (sometimes called the “new formalists”) have sought to join formalism to historical approaches by showing how literary forms emerge out of political situations dominated by specific contests or debates. Since the late 1990s, literary critics like Susan Wolfson and Heather Dubrow have argued that literary forms reflect or respond to contemporary political conditions.¹⁴ Forms matter, in these accounts, because they shape what it is possible to think, say, and do in a given context.

Forms: *containing*, *plural*, *overlapping*, *portable*, and *situated*. None of these ideas about form are themselves new, but putting them together will bring us to a new theory of form.

Affordances

How can form do so many different, even contradictory things? How can it be both political and aesthetic, both containing and plural, both situated and portable? To capture the complex operations of social and literary forms, I borrow the concept of *affordance* from design theory. *Affordance* is a term used to describe the potential uses or actions latent in materials and designs.¹⁵ Glass affords transparency and brittleness. Steel affords strength, smoothness, hardness, and durability. Cotton affords fluffiness, but also breathable cloth when it is spun into yarn and thread. Specific designs, which organize these materials, then lay claim to their own range of affordances. A fork affords stabbing and scooping. A door-knob affords not only hardness and durability, but also turning, pushing, and pulling. Designed things may also have unexpected affordances generated by imaginative users: we may hang signs or clothes on a doorknob, for example, or use a fork to pry open a lid, and so expand the intended affordances of an object.

Let's now use affordances to think about form. The advantage of this perspective is that it allows us to grasp both the specificity and the generality of forms—both the particular constraints and possibilities that different forms afford, and the fact that those patterns and arrangements carry their affordances with them as they move across time and space. What is a walled enclosure or a rhyming couplet *capable* of doing? Each shape or pattern, social or literary, lays claim to a limited range of potentialities. Enclosures afford containment and security, inclusion as well as exclusion. Rhyme affords repetition, anticipation, and memorization. Networks afford connection and circulation, and narratives afford the connection of events over time. The sonnet, brief and condensed, best affords a single idea or experience, “a moment's monument,”¹⁶ while the triple-decker novel affords elaborate processes of character development in multiplot social contexts. Forms are limiting and containing, yes, but in crucially different ways. Each form can only do so much.

To be sure, a specific form can be put to use in unexpected ways that expand our general sense of that form's affordances. Rather than asking what artists intend or even what forms *do*, we can ask instead what potentialities lie latent—though not always obvious—in aesthetic and social

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arrangements. An imaginative user, such as William Butler Yeats, deliberately pushes at the limits of formal constraints in “Leda and the Swan,” a sonnet that captures the single moment that launches the epic story of the Trojan War—at once gesturing to the sweep of epic while remaining powerfully constrained by the sonnet’s compact form.

Although each form lays claim to different affordances, all forms do share one affordance. Precisely because they are abstract organizing principles, shapes and patterns are iterable—portable. They can be picked up and moved to new contexts. A school borrows the idea of spectators in rows from ancient theater. A novelist takes from epic poetry the narrative structure of the quest. Forms also afford movement across varied materials. A rhythm can impose its powerful order on laboring bodies as well as odes. Binary oppositions can structure gendered workspaces as well as creation myths. While its meanings and values may change, the pattern or shape itself can remain surprisingly stable across contexts. But as they move, forms bring their limited range of affordances with them. No matter how different their historical and cultural circumstances, that is, bounded enclosures will always exclude, and rhyme will always repeat.

If forms lay claim to a limited range of potentialities and constraints, if they afford the same limited range of actions wherever they travel, and if they are the stuff of politics, then attending to the affordances of form opens up a *generalizable understanding of political power*. A panoptic arrangement of space, wherever it takes shape, will always afford a certain kind of disciplinary power; a hierarchy will always afford inequality.

But specific contexts also matter. In any given circumstance, no form operates in isolation. The idea of affordances is valuable for understanding the aesthetic object as imposing its order among a vast array of designed things, from prison cells to doorknobs. Literary form does not operate outside of the social but works among many organizing principles, all circulating in a world jam-packed with other arrangements. Each constraint will encounter many other, different organizing principles, and its power to impose order will itself be constrained, and at times unsettled, by other forms. Rhyme and narrative may structure the same text; the gender binary and the bureaucratic hierarchy may coincide in a single workplace. Which will organize the other? It is not always predictable. New encounters may activate latent affordances or foreclose otherwise dominant ones. Forms will often fail to impose their order when they run up against other forms that disrupt their logic and frustrate their organizing ends, producing aleatory and sometimes contradictory effects. We can understand forms as abstract and portable organizing principles, then, but we also need to attend to the

specificity of particular historical situations to understand the range of ways in which forms overlap and collide.

In many cases, when forms meet, their collision produces unexpected consequences, results that cannot always be traced back to deliberate intentions or dominant ideologies. In a brief but familiar example, most women in academia experience a powerful tension between the biological “clock”—the years when the female body is capable of biological reproduction—and the tenure clock—the university’s timetable for evaluating probationary faculty. This is one reason why a disproportionately high number of women opt for academic jobs as adjuncts and part-timers.¹⁷ Since the tenure system predates the entry of women in any substantial numbers into the academy, these consequences do not flow from any particular patriarchal intention or ideology other than the assumption of an uninterrupted adult life.¹⁸ In other words, this clash of temporal forms does not result from an intention to keep women in their places; it is an unplanned collision between two temporal forms, one biological and the other institutional.

Even a prison cell, the grimmest of social forms, does not enforce its simple, single order in isolation. The cell itself is a straightforward enough form: it encloses bodies within surrounding walls. But the prison always activates other forms as well: prisoners are subjected to temporal patterns, including enforced daily rhythms of food, sleep, and exercise; educational trajectories; and the length of the prison term itself. They take part in networks that operate not only within a given prison, but also reach outside the confines of prison walls, including illegal smuggling rings, gangs, and correspondence networks. The latter—from Amnesty International to personal notes to the “Letter from Birmingham Jail”—have long been crucial forms in prisoners’ lives. And at the same time as prisoners are contained in cells, patterned in time, and linked to various networks, they are also subjected to numerous painful hierarchies, ranked according to the status of their crimes and their gender and sexual identities. As these forms overlap, some may disrupt the prison cell’s containing power. The enclosure of the cell itself does not readily afford expansion or breakdown, but the temporal form of the prison sentence affords shortening or lengthening. And one surprisingly literary form has occasionally cut short the time of a prison term: a story of remorse or redemption can sometimes prompt a pardon.¹⁹ Thus the arc of a narrative can in its own way pry open a cell’s enclosing walls.

This analysis of forms—constraining in different ways, bringing their affordances with them as they cross contexts, and colliding to sometimes unpredictable effect—points to a new understanding of how power works. And yet, one might object, if so many things count as forms, from sonnets

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to prison cells to tenure clocks, then the category is just too capacious. What in this account is *not* form? Is there any way outside or beyond form? My own answer is yes—there are many events and experiences that do not count as forms—and we could certainly pay close attention to these: fissures and interstices, vagueness and indeterminacy, boundary-crossing and dissolution. But I want to make the case here that these formless or antiformal experiences have actually drawn *too much* attention from literary and cultural critics in the past few decades.

That is, the field has been so concerned with breaking forms apart that we have neglected to analyze the major work that forms do in our world. We have tended to assume that political forms are powerful, all-encompassing, and usually simple in themselves: a sexist or racist regime, for example, splits the world into a crude and comprehensive binary, its stark simplicity—black and white, masculine and feminine—contributing to the regime's painful power. We have therefore learned to look for places where the binary breaks down or dissolves, generating possibilities that turn the form into something more ambiguous and ill-defined—formless. Scholars in recent years have written a great deal about indeterminate spaces and identities, employing such key terms as liminality, borders, migration, hybridity, and passing.²⁰ This work has been compelling and politically important, without any doubt, and it will surely continue to be productive to analyze formal failures, incompleteness, and indefinability. But while it may be possible to rid ourselves of particular unjust totalities or binaries, it is impossible to imagine a society altogether free of organizing principles. And too strong an emphasis on forms' dissolution has prevented us from attending to the complex ways that power operates in a world dense with functioning forms.

Perhaps this account of form still seems too abstract, too divorced from material conditions and the ways that power operates on and through embodied experience. A continued focus on affordances will help us here. The term *affordance* crosses back and forth between materiality and design. It certainly helps us to understand the capacities and limitations of materials. Wood affords hard, durable structures. It does not afford fluid streams or spongy softness. A wire affords connection and transmission, and chocolate affords structured shapes as well as a certain gooey viscosity. With affordances, then, we can begin to grasp the constraints on form that are imposed by materiality itself. One cannot make a poem out of soup or a panopticon out of wool. In this sense, form and materiality are inextricable, and materiality is determinant.

But patterns and arrangements also shape matter, imposing order on stone and flesh, sounds and spaces. Constraint moves in both directions.

Things take forms, and forms organize things. The prison cell cannot do its work without the hard materiality of metal or stone, but it also operates as an iterable way of organizing experience, a model of enclosure that can and does travel across many contexts. It is both a thing and a form. Henry S. Turner suggests that we can discover forms from two opposite starting-points: we can begin with the immaterial, abstract organizing principles that shape material realities, or we can begin with the concrete, particular material thing and abstract from it to general, iterable patterns and shapes.²¹ From either perspective, forms travel across time and space in and through situated material objects.²²

The relationship between materiality and form has long been of interest in literary studies. Critics have often assumed that the materiality of a text's content lends itself to certain literary forms: patterns of labor or rhythms of the body yielding certain repetitions in poetry, for example. In one recent essay, Stephanie Markovits argues that nineteenth-century literary writers in different genres often chose to write about diamonds because these objects are suited both to the "containment of lyric" thanks to their perfectly chiseled shapes, and to the motion of narrative, thanks to their extraordinary durability over time.²³ Or to put this in terms of affordances, the materiality of diamonds affords specific experiences of time, including stillness and durability, which the critic then reads as shaping the literary forms that incorporate them. There is a rich suggestiveness in this kind of analysis, but it is important to note that the materials described or evoked by literary texts do not determine their forms in the same way that stone determines durability. Literature is not made of the material world it describes or invokes but of language, which lays claims to its own forms—syntactical, narrative, rhythmic, rhetorical—and its own materiality—the spoken word, the printed page. And indeed, each of these forms and materials lays claim to its own affordances—its own range of capabilities. Every literary form thus generates its own, separate logic. The most common literary formalist reading method involves binding literary forms to their contents, seeking out the ways that each reflects the other, as Markovits does with diamonds. But a typical novel or poem will touch on so many different objects—diamonds and hair, chocolate and the ocean—that it could not possibly adjust its own forms to every material it incorporates. Thus a reading practice that follows the affordances of both literary forms and material objects imagines these as mutually shaping potentialities, but does not fold one into the other, as if the materiality of the extratextual world were the ultimate determinant.

Affordances point us both to what all forms are capable of—to the range of uses each could be put to, even if no one has yet taken advantage of those

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possibilities—and also to their limits, the restrictions intrinsic to particular materials and organizing principles. Ballot boxes, biological clocks, and lyric poems all take organizing forms. Each of these forms can be repeated elsewhere, and each carries with it a certain limited range of affordances as it travels. But a form does its work only in contexts where other political and aesthetic forms also are operating. A variety of forms are in motion around us, constraining materials in a range of ways and imposing their order in situated contexts where they constantly overlap other forms. Form emerges from this perspective as transhistorical, portable, and abstract, on the one hand, and material, situated, and political, on the other.

Rethinking Formalisms

With affordances in mind, we can see how forms can be at once containing, plural, overlapping, portable, and situated. But every major formalist tradition has limited its definition of form in a way that has missed or excluded one or more of these affordances. For example, we have long known that the New Critics missed something important when they understood literary forms as entirely separate from a situated and material social world. They overlooked the ways in which formal constraints might matter politically; they did not care that forms took shape in specific historical circumstances. But the New Criticism was also interested in some of the affordances of form that have been missing from other theories. In literary and cultural studies, we have a much less refined vocabulary for the differences between social forms than we have for aesthetic ones. Certainly we know that racial hierarchies and walled enclosures organize social groups in different ways, but we have not developed a language for those differences. The New Criticism, with its interest in the differences between forms, can actually point the way forward here, inviting us to develop a richer and more precise terminology for the work of social forms. The New Critics also showed that it is difficult—if not impossible—to exhaust the dense interweaving of formal elements in a short lyric poem. And if it is a challenge to identify and analyze the shaping elements of a single sonnet, then it is certainly impossible to capture the patterns constitutive of an entire society with a handful of categories, such as race, class, gender, nationality, sexuality, and disability. Thus the New Critics' focus on the extraordinary plurality of overlapping forms could prompt us to expand the logic of intersectional analysis dramatically, continuing to take the structures of race, class, and gender extremely seriously, but tracking the encounters of these with many other kinds of forms, from enclosures to networks to narrative resolutions.

The politically minded “new formalisms” that have emerged in literary studies recently have also overlooked one of form’s crucial affordances. These critics have insisted on situating literary forms in particular political contexts. Mostly, they have followed one of two paths. Some have read literary forms as legible reflections of social structures. Herbert F. Tucker, for example, reads the meter of Elizabeth Barrett Browning’s poem, “The Cry of the Children,” as revealing the uncomfortable disjuncture between the embodied time of human life and the jolting experience of factory labor. Barrett Browning’s “stop-and-start versification mimics the strain and clatter of steam-driven machinery.”²⁴ A second group casts literary form less as a reflection of a specific social context than as a deliberate *intervention*. Susan Wolfson argues, for example, that the Romantic poets were hardly unknowing purveyors of a “romantic ideology” that masked political struggle in unified “organic forms,” as has often been charged: instead, she argues, they were fully aware of the constructedness of literary unities and purposefully deployed formal strategies to investigate problems of ideology, subjectivity, and social conditions.²⁵ Both groups of new formalists read literary form as epiphenomenal, growing out of specific social conditions that it mimics or opposes. Thus, neither camp takes account of one of forms’ affordances: the capacity to endure across time and space. From the gender binary to rhyme and from prison cells to narrative prose, aesthetic and social forms outlive the specific conditions that gave birth to them: the scroll does not altogether disappear with the codex but in fact reemerges with surprising pervasiveness in the age of the Internet; the quest structure of ancient epic remains available to the contemporary novelist. None of these forms spring up anew in response to particular social facts but instead hang around, available for reuse. In this sense, forms are not outgrowths of social conditions; they do not belong to certain times and places.

And indeed, as sociologist Marc Schneiberg argues, it is precisely the endurance of “holdover” forms that can make a society promisingly plural, scattered with alternative ways of organizing resources and goods that could at any moment give rise to more hopeful arrangements. For example, in the 1950s when large, private, for-profit corporations started to dominate the US economic landscape, electricity—crucial to the whole economy—was delivered in significant quantities by local, state-owned enterprises and cooperatives. Every day, when corporate moguls turned on the lights, they remobilized the form of cooperative ownership. The story of US capitalism is therefore not only a deep-rooted dialectical struggle between capital and labor, but also “a path littered with elements or fragments of more or less developed systems of alternatives—a path ripe for exploitation,

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institutional revitalization and assembly, and containing within it structural possibilities for alternatives.”²⁶ What would enrich and deepen the “new formalism,” then, is attention to the *longues durées* of different forms, their portability across time and space.

Genre theory, too, could benefit from more attention to the portability of forms. For many critics, the terms *form* and *genre* are synonymous or near-synonymous.²⁷ But this book argues that they can be differentiated precisely by the different ways in which they traverse time and space. Genre involves acts of classifying texts. An ensemble of characteristics, including styles, themes, and marketing conventions, allows both producers and audiences to group texts into certain kinds. Innovations can alter those expectations: an experimental epic might invite readers to expand their sense of the genre’s themes, while the introduction of print extends and transforms a folktale’s audience. Thus any attempt to recognize a work’s genre is a historically specific and interpretive act: one might not be able to tell the difference between a traditional folktale and a story recently composed for children or to recognize a satire from a distant historical moment.²⁸

Forms, defined as patternings, shapes, and arrangements, have a different relation to context: they can organize both social and literary objects, and they can remain stable over time. One has to agree to read for shapes and patterns, of course, and this is itself a conventional approach. But as Frances Ferguson argues, once we recognize the organizing principles of different literary forms—such as syntax, free indirect speech, and the sonnet—they are themselves no longer matters of interpretive activity or debate: “Even if you failed to notice that the sonnet that Romeo and Juliet speak between them was a sonnet the first time you read Shakespeare’s play, you would be able to recognize it as such from the moment that someone pointed it out to you. . . . It could be regularly found, pointed out, or returned to, and the sense of its availability would not rest on agreements about its meaning.”²⁹ Similarly, it is difficult not to agree on the shape of the classroom or the schedule of the prisoner’s day, the hierarchy of a bureaucratic organization or the structure of a kinship system. There is certainly some abstraction entailed here, but once we have agreed to look for principles of organization, we will probably not spend much time disputing the idea that racial apartheid organizes social life into a hierarchical binary, or that nation-states enforce territorial boundaries. More stable than genre, configurations and arrangements organize materials in distinct and iterable ways no matter what their context or audience. Forms thus migrate across contexts in a way that genres cannot. They also work on different scales, as small as punctuation marks and as vast as multiplot narratives or national boundaries. Genres,

then, can be defined as customary constellations of elements into historically recognizable groupings of artistic objects, bringing together forms with themes, styles, and situations of reception, while forms are organizations or arrangements that afford repetition and portability across materials and contexts.

So far, then, we have seen that the New Criticism missed the political power and the situatedness of constraining forms, intersectional analysis has overlooked the extraordinary plurality of forms at work in social situations, and the new formalists and genre theorists have too often neglected the capacity of forms to endure across time and space. Let us think finally about what has been missing from the Marxist tradition, the most complex and robust school of formalist thinking in literary and cultural studies.

Many Marxist thinkers, from Georg Lukács and Pierre Macherey to Fredric Jameson and Franco Moretti, have cast literary form as an ideological artifice, a neat structuring of representation that soothes us into a false sense of order, preventing us from coming to terms with a reality that always exceeds form. Hayden White, for example, argues that narrative form teaches people to live in “an unreal but meaningful relation to the social formations in which they are indentured to live out their lives and realize their destinies as social subjects.”³⁰ White contrasts reality—which he calls “social formations”—with the unreal coherence of narrative form. But if we understand social formations—such as the gender binary and the prison timetable—as themselves organizing forms, then we can see that White’s real-unreal distinction does not hold. Literary forms and social formations are equally real in their capacity to organize materials, and equally *unreal* in being artificial, contingent constraints. Instead of seeking to reveal the reality suppressed by literary forms, we can understand sociopolitical life as itself composed of a plurality of different forms, from narrative to marriage and from bureaucracy to racism.

The Marxist emphasis on aesthetic form as epiphenomenal—as secondary—has some distorting effects. First, it prevents us from understanding politics as a matter of form, and second, it assumes that one kind of form—the political—is always the root or ground of the other—the aesthetic. Let me offer an example of what it would mean to read literary forms not as epiphenomenal responses to social realities but as forms encountering other forms.

The gender binary is a form that can impose its order on the home, the laboratory, the prison, dress, and many other facts of social life. Now let’s consider an encounter between the gender binary and a narrative, Thomas Hughes’s best-selling novel *Tom Brown’s Schooldays* (1857). The narrative

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begins by establishing a fiercely masculine world: the all-boy Rugby School, which is a training-ground for Christian colonial power.³¹ Tom, the protagonist, undergoes a series of adventures: a race, a football match, a fight with bullies. In every case, he succeeds by standing firm, and as a result the first half of the novel becomes remarkably repetitive, testing the hero in the same way over and over again. He meets each challenge, like “all real boys,” by refusing to give ground.³² But the narrative form of *Tom Brown's School-days* takes an odd turn halfway through. It becomes more narratively interesting, and also, strangely, suddenly feminine. The wise headmaster Thomas Arnold decides that Tom and his friends must become more mature. He assigns Tom a new boy to look after, “a slight pale boy, with large blue eyes and light fair hair, who seemed ready to shrink through the floor . . . would be afraid of wet feet, and always getting laughed at, and called Molly, or Jenny, or some derogatory feminine nickname” (217–18). Saddled with responsibility for another, Tom becomes anxious and learns to submit to God. He is so careful of the younger boy's welfare that he becomes feminine himself, “like a hen with one chick” (231). If the hero is victorious in the first half because he manfully withstands a series of assaults, the second half turns him into a pliable, recognizably feminine character: yielding, submissive, and open to alterity. The narrative suddenly becomes a *Bildungsroman*, a novel of development, filled with lessons learned and changes in the protagonist's outlook and values.

What is going on here? One could say that Thomas Hughes wanted a narratively rich resource like the *Bildungsroman* to transform his repetitive, static story of boyish adventures into a more satisfying arc. The gender binary would have come in handy for this purpose, since the opposite of the brave, unyielding masculine character was the anxious, feminine one, open to change in precisely the way required for *Bildung*. According to this account, Hughes would have incorporated femininity into the text as an aftereffect of his narrative desires. Conversely, we could argue that because he valued a submissive Christianity, Hughes gravitated to the yielding character of the *Bildungsroman*, tractable in a way that fell on the feminine side of the gender binary, and adopted the narrative form of the pliable character as an aftereffect of his religious convictions. We don't know which came first. What we do know is that both the literary and the social form—*Bildung* and the gender binary—preexist the text in question. Both move from other sites into this text, carrying their own ways of organizing experience with them. While we might speculate about which form is primary, or about Hughes's own motivations, the text itself shows us something interesting about what happens when narrative form encounters the gender

binary and the two begin to operate together. In fact, a predictable, generalizable hypothesis about form unfolds from this collision, regardless of the author's intentions or the origins of either form. As long as pliability—the susceptibility to development—falls on the feminine side of the gender binary, the *Bildungsroman* will have to be a feminine genre, even when its protagonists are male.

Most Marxist formalist critics would approach the narrative form of *Tom Brown's Schooldays* as the working out of an ideological position or as an “abstract of social relationships.”³³ Most politically minded new formalists would read the text as a response to the immediate social world around it. The formalism that emerges here is different: I read narrative and gender as two distinct forms, each striving to impose its own order, both traveling from other places to the text in question, and neither automatically prior or dominant. One might say that I am flipping White's terms upside down: rather than hunting for the buried *content of the form*, I propose here to track *the forms of the content*, the many organizing principles that encounter one another inside as well as outside of the literary text. Instead of assuming that social forms are the grounds or causes of literary forms, and instead of imagining that a literary text has *a* form, this book asks two unfamiliar questions: what does each form afford, and what happens when forms meet?

From Causation to Collision

The first major goal of this book is to show that forms are everywhere structuring and patterning experience, and that this carries serious implications for understanding political communities. This starting-point entails a *Gestalt* shift for literary studies. It calls for a new account of politics and of the relations between politics and literature. In theory, political forms impose their order on our lives, putting us in our places. But in practice, we encounter so many forms that even in the most ordinary daily experience they add up to a complex environment composed of multiple and conflicting modes of organization—forms arranging and containing us, yes, but also competing and colliding and rerouting one another. I will make the case here that no form, however seemingly powerful, causes, dominates, or organizes all others. This means that literary forms can lay claim to an efficacy of their own. They do not simply reflect or contain prior political realities. As different forms struggle to impose their order on our experience, working at different scales of our experience, aesthetic and political forms emerge as comparable patterns that operate on a common plane. I will show in this book that aesthetic and political forms may be nested inside one another,

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and that each is capable of disturbing the other's organizing power.

This is not to say, however, that the world of forms is a happy free-for-all. The second major goal of the book is to think about the ways that, together, the multiple forms of the world come into conflict and disorganize experience in ways that call for unconventional political strategies. Critics and theorists have tended to assume that powerful social institutions integrate and homogenize experience; they put into practice coherent ideologies that organize and constrain experience. This book puts an emphasis on social *disorganization*, exploring the many ways in which multiple forms of order, sometimes the results of the same powerful ideological formation, may unsettle one another. And yet, disorganization is not always better than order, and we will see how competing forms can sometimes produce pain and injustice as troubling as any consolidation of power.

Approaching form in this pluralizing way to include both social and aesthetic forms, and arguing that no single form dominates or organizes all of the others, moves us away from one of the deepest political convictions in the field: that ultimately, it is deep structural forces such as capitalism, nationalism, and racism that are the truly powerful shapers of our lives. Critics are not wrong to hold on to such explanations: our lives are certainly organized by powerful structuring principles, and it would be a grave mistake to overlook them. But at the same time I would argue that an exclusive focus on ultimate causality has not necessarily benefited leftist politics. It has distracted us from thinking strategically about how best to deploy multiple forms for political ends.

My work has been influenced here by Brazilian legal theorist and politician Roberto Mangabeira Unger, who makes the case that too strong an analytic emphasis on deep structures is disabling for radical politics. It limits our attention and our targets to a small number of the most intractable factors, factors so difficult to unsettle that most people abandon the attempt altogether. What if we were to see social life instead as composed of "loosely and unevenly collected" arrangements, "a makeshift, pasted-together" order rather than a coherent system that can be traced back to a single cause? Unger argues that such an approach would draw attention to the artificiality and contingency of social arrangements and so open up a new set of opportunities for real change by way of feasible rearrangements.³⁴ Like Unger, Jacques Rancière too draws attention to the radical potential that lies in acts of rearrangement.³⁵

The formalism I propose here draws from Unger and Rancière to shift attention away from deep causes to a recognition of the many different shapes and patterns that constitute political, cultural, and social experience.

I draw attention in particular to the ways that different arrangements can collide to strange effect, with minor forms sometimes disrupting or rerouting major ones. In a context of many overlapping forms, the most significant challenge for political actors is the fact that complicating any single form one might advocate are multiple organizing principles always already at work, often clashing and interrupting and rerouting one another. These overlaps open up unfamiliar opportunities for political action and show why the most effective route to social change might not be traditional ideology critique, which aims to expose the false and seductive discourses and cultural practices that prevent us from recognizing human unfreedom, that universalize and naturalize the oppressive social structures that stand in the way of emancipation. If forms always contain and confine, and if it is impossible to imagine societies without forms, then the most strategic political action will not come from revealing or exposing illusion, but rather from a careful, nuanced understanding of the many different and often disconnected arrangements that govern social experience.

Carolyn Lesjak has recently argued against the version of formalism I articulate here, because she sees it as a recipe for political quietism.³⁶ But in fact the primary goal of this formalism is radical social change. All politics, including revolutionary political action, will succeed only if it is canny about deploying multiple forms. Revolutions must mobilize certain arrangements, certain organized forms of resistance—the takeover of the public square, the strike, the boycott, the coalition. And any redistribution of the world’s wealth, which I strongly favor, must follow some kind of organizing principle. Marx’s classic slogan, “From each according to one’s ability; to each according to one’s need,” is a careful balancing of inputs and outputs, a structural parallelism that might well govern the organization of energies and distributions in a radical and just new order. Which forms do we wish to see governing social life, then, and which forms of protest or resistance actually succeed at dismantling unjust, entrenched arrangements?

My focus on the movement and assembly of forms prompts me to rely on a kind of event I call the “collision”—the strange encounter between two or more forms that sometimes reroutes intention and ideology. I offer many examples of such collisions, in part to unsettle the power of another explanatory form in literary and cultural studies: the dialectic. Literary and cultural studies has of course long been influenced by Marx’s dialectical materialism, and the structuralists, by identifying binary oppositions as a basic structure of social life, broadened dialectical thinking beyond Marxism within the field. Indeed, since the structuralist moment, it has been easy to spot dialectical structures at work everywhere, their dynamic op-

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positional energies providing the animating force behind historical change: “the dialectic of good and evil, but also that of subject and object; the dialectic of rich and poor and also that of male and female or black and white; the dialectic of Right and Left, but also of poetry and prose, high culture and mass culture, science and ideology, materialism and idealism, harmony and counterpoint, color and line, self and other, and so on. . . .”³⁷ But while it is no doubt true that much painful historical experience has emerged out of deep social contradictions, I argue in this book that the binary opposition is just one of a number of powerfully organizing forms, and that many outcomes follow from other forms, as well as from more mundane, more minor, and more contingent formal encounters, where different forms are not necessarily related, opposed, or deeply expressive, but simply happen to cross paths at a particular site. Suspending the usual models of causality thus produces new insight into the work of forms, both social and aesthetic.

Narrative

The form that best captures the experience of colliding forms is narrative. It is by no means the only form I will use or examine in this book, but it is a particularly helpful one for the analysis of forms at work. What narrative form affords is a careful attention to the ways in which forms come together, and to what happens when and after they meet. Narratives are especially appealing for a skeptical formalist reader because they tend to present causality metonymically, through sequences of events, rather than by positing some originary cause. They afford “conjoining,” to use David Hume’s words, rather than “necessary connexion.”³⁸ Narratives are valuable heuristic forms, then, because they can set in motion multiple social forms and track them as they cooperate, come into conflict, and overlap, without positing an ultimate cause.

Since social forms can move across contexts, taking their range of affordances with them, they can reveal their potentialities in fiction as well as nonfiction. We saw gender at work in *Tom Brown’s Schooldays*. As a formalist reader, I put my stress not on the fact that gender is a social fact being conveyed or registered by the literary text, but that it is a binary form that *carries its affordances with it into the novel*. Bruno Latour mentions in passing that fiction writers often do better than sociologists at capturing social relations because they are free to experiment, offering “a vast playground to rehearse accounts of what makes us act.”³⁹ Like Latour, I treat fictional narratives as productive thought experiments that allow us to imagine the subtle unfolding activity of multiple social forms.

My interest in the collision and unfolding of forms prompts me to pay an unusually serious kind of attention to plot. Not all plots are equally interesting, and I focus most of my attention here on a few extraordinary ones. Sophocles's *Antigone*, Charles Dickens's *Bleak House*, and David Simon's *The Wire* present the movement of forms in exceptionally shrewd and unconventional ways that expand a conventional sense of how social worlds work. I spend time in this book describing narrative unfolding in each of these works.

This may seem like a surprising approach for a formalist reader. Following the plot has rarely been considered a sophisticated or valuable interpretive practice by any literary school, and describing the movement of narrative events might risk what New Critic Cleanth Brooks most strongly decried as the "heresy of paraphrase." For Brooks, literary objects are unlike other texts because they are organized by a "principle of unity" that ultimately harmonizes unlike and sometimes conflicting elements—rhythms, images, connotations—into a balanced whole. The problem with paraphrase, in his view, is that simple statements or propositions about the world always fail to capture the poem's subtle interactions among various parts.⁴⁰ In the next chapter of this book, I will subject Brooks's insistence on unity to critique. But in the meanwhile, I want to suggest that my enthusiastic embrace of plot paraphrase does take up his New Critical project in one specific way: plot is difficult to reduce to a single message or statement, and as a form it too mobilizes the subtle interrelations of multiple elements. Unlike a taxonomic chart that organizes forms into separate categories, narrative privileges the interaction of forms over time. Paraphrasing plotted narrative thus yields an irreducible complexity that is ironically consonant with the aims and values of the New Critics.

To return to *Jane Eyre*, for example, we can read the section that deals with Lowood School as a thoughtful investigation of how disciplinary forms can unfold in intricate interrelation, their patterning of experience capable of crossing back and forth between fiction and the social world. Sometimes the school's forms work perfectly together: a timed bell signals a shift in spatial order; a student who obediently follows both spatial and temporal arrangements successfully climbs the ranks. But not always: an unjust punishment by the top of the school's patriarchal hierarchy gives rise to a dissident, nonpatriarchal network as Miss Temple, Helen Burns, and Jane Eyre come together to create a new social form, a triadic "counter-family."⁴¹ In the sheltered privacy of Miss Temple's room, other forms then come into play. Miss Temple invites Jane to defend herself against the accusations of Mr Brocklehurst according to the rules set forth

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by courts of law. Jane gives her own testimony “coherently” and in a “restrained and simplified” manner that convinces her audience of her innocence and allows her to be publicly cleared (83). Thus a clandestine network of women, a closed room, the rules of the courtroom, and a newly organized and controlled kind of storytelling come together to resist Mr Brocklehurst’s authority.

This interaction of forms also brings with it some strange side effects. It throws into an odd kind of disarray another form—the binary division between public and private—as the secret courtroom, which joins intimate storytelling with the adoption of impersonal, public rules, permits a public exoneration of Jane. The hierarchy of the school, too, becomes oddly double, emerging as both enabling and tyrannical, since Jane’s exoneration gives her the confidence to climb Lowood’s ladder, while at the same time refusing Mr Brocklehurst the power that is supposed to derive from his place at the top of the same ladder. Meanwhile, the model of the courtroom teaches Jane how to tell stories that work for her own ends—carefully arranged and simplified to win over audiences. Thus the plotted form of the narrative itself takes shape at the intersection of a number of other forms—a hierarchy, an enclosed space, a network, and a set of legal rules.

This is an example of a reading practice that does not fit any familiar formalism. But it draws from all of them.

Whole, Rhythm, Hierarchy, Network

Organizing this book are four major forms. These are by no means the only forms, but they are particularly common, pervasive—and also significant. Though we have not always called them forms, they are the political structures that have most concerned literary and cultural studies scholars: bounded *wholes*, from domestic walls to national boundaries; temporal *rhythms*, from the repetitions of industrial labor to the enduring patterns of institutions over time; powerful *hierarchies*, including gender, race, class, and bureaucracy; and *networks* that link people and objects, including multinational trade, terrorism, and transportation. All of these have resonant corollaries in literature and literary studies: the bounded whole has long been a model for lyric poetry and narrative closure; rhythmic tempos organize poetic meter and sometimes literary history itself; hierarchies organize literary texts’ investments in certain values and characters over others; and networks link national cultures, writers, and characters.

Each chapter takes up one of these forms as it organizes literary works, social institutions, and our knowledge of both literature and the social—

that is, scholarly conversations in the field. For each of the major forms we will encounter in this book, I will ask four sets of questions:

- 1 What specific order does each form impose? The chapters that follow make the case that simply attending carefully to the affordances of each form produces some surprising new conclusions: for example, that what we call narrative closure does not in fact enclose, and that one of the most famous of the supposedly formalist New Critics paid not too much but too little attention to lyric form.
- 2 How has scholarly knowledge itself depended on certain organizing forms to establish its own claims, and how might a self-consciousness about scholarly forms shift the arguments that literary and cultural studies scholars make? I spend time here showing how some of the most determinedly antiformalist scholars have necessarily depended on organizing forms in their own arguments.
- 3 How should we understand the relationship between literary and political forms? Moving beyond the practice of reading aesthetic forms as indexes of social life, I consider ways in which literary and social forms come into contact and affect one another, without presuming that one is the ground or cause of the other.
- 4 Finally, what political strategies—what tactics for change—will work most effectively if what we are facing is not a single hegemonic system or dominant ideology but many forms, all trying to organize us at once? If politics operates through different kinds of forms—spatial containers, repetitions and durations over time, vertical arrangements of high and low, networks of interconnection—then resistance to one of these may not emancipate us from the others. It might even establish or reinforce the power of another form. The most significant and challenging claim of this book is that many, many forms are organizing us at all times. Where exactly, then, can we locate the best opportunities for social change in a world of overlapping forms? Can we set one form against another or introduce a new form that would reroute a racial hierarchy or disturb exclusionary boundaries? I argue that we need a fine-grained formalist reading practice to address the extraordinary density of forms that is a fact of our most ordinary daily experience.

A great variety of formal examples will make their appearances in this book: theme parks and management hierarchies, classical tragedies and

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well-wrought urns, literary history and gender theory. This wide-ranging array establishes the portability of the method, showing that this approach can productively cross sites and institutions, from medieval convents to modernist sculpture, from the early American postal system to postcolonial criticism. Though I will draw many examples from Victorian Britain because this is the field I know best, this is a project that necessarily carries us far from any given period of literary or cultural study.

A final chapter will offer a surprising, even counterintuitive, paradigm for bringing all four major forms together. HBO's remarkable recent television series, *The Wire* (2002–2008), conceptualizes social life as both structured and rendered radically unpredictable by large numbers of colliding social forms, including bounded wholes, rhythms, hierarchies, and networks. Dependent on a narrative logic that traces the effects of each formal encounter on the next, it refuses to posit a deep, prior, metaphysical model of causality to explain its world. By tracking vast numbers of social patterns as they meet, reroute, and disrupt one another, *The Wire* examines the world that results from a plurality of forms at work. I argue that this series could provide a new model for literary and cultural studies scholarship.

Intended to act as a methodological starting-point, this book proposes a way to understand the relations among forms—forms aesthetic and social, spatial and temporal, ancient and modern, major and minor, like and unlike, punitive and narrative, material and metrical. Its method of tracking shapes and arrangements is not confined to the literary text or to the aesthetic, but it does involve a kind of close reading, a careful attention to the forms that organize texts, bodies, and institutions. “Close but not deep,” to borrow Heather Love's elegant formulation, this is a practice that seeks out pattern over meaning, the intricacy of relations over interpretive depth.⁴² And yet, at the same time, this is also a method that builds on what literary critics have traditionally done best—reading for complex interrelationships and multiple, overlapping arrangements. I argue that it is time to *export* those practices, to take our traditional skills to new objects—the social structures and institutions that are among the most crucial sites of political efficacy. I seek to show that there is a great deal to be learned about power by observing different forms of order as they operate in the world. And I want to persuade those who are interested in politics to become formalists, so that we can begin to intervene in the conflicting formal logics that turn out to organize and disorganize our lives, constantly producing not only painful disposessions but also surprising opportunities.

HIERARCHY

The word *hierarchy* comes from the Greek *hieros*, meaning “sacred,” and *arche*, meaning “rule.” The term was first used in the sixth century CE, when it referred to levels of angelic choruses, but it soon came to be applied to the governance of the Church, to describe its strictly ordered levels of authority and subordination. Gradually, from the fourteenth to the seventeenth centuries, its meaning widened beyond the religious context to apply to the natural sciences and to society more generally.¹ These days it can refer to organizations, values, and social relationships.

It is not difficult to understand hierarchies, like bounded wholes and rhythms, as forms: hierarchies arrange bodies, things, and ideas according to levels of power or importance. Hierarchies rank—organizing experience into asymmetrical, discriminatory, often deeply unjust arrangements. The most consistent and painful affordance of hierarchical structures is inequality. Hierarchies are in this respect the most troubling of all the forms we will consider in this book.

Across the humanities, hierarchies have drawn a great deal of attention, as scholars have sought to understand why and how such flagrantly unequal structures succeed in imposing their order on the world. Since the 1970s, theorists have paid especially close attention to the binary oppositions that organize a great deal of cultural and political experience: masculinity and femininity, public and private, mind and body, black and white. These had seemed universal and simply neutral to structuralist thinkers like anthropologist Claude Lévi-Strauss in the 1950s and 1960s.² But the post-structuralists who followed argued that these binaries were always covertly hierarchical and that their seeming neutrality had justified violence and inequality for centuries.

Since the Greeks, the poststructuralists argued, Western thought had longed to ground transcendent truth in a single, foundational concept, such as reason, mind, man, or the public sphere. Philosophers tried to establish the identity of each fundamental concept through what it was not, defining reason against madness, mind against body, man against woman, public against private. And what poststructuralist thinkers argued was that the

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second term—the excluded other (madness, body, woman)—always emerged as degraded or abjected. As the philosopher Elizabeth Grosz puts it:

Dichotomous thinking necessarily hierarchizes and ranks the two polarized terms so that one becomes the privileged term and the other its suppressed, subordinated, negative counterpart. The subordinated term is merely the negation or denial, the absence or privation of the primary term, its fall from grace; the primary term defines itself by expelling its other and in this process establishes its own boundaries and borders to create an identity for itself.³

Grosz, like many others, has argued that foundational hierarchical binaries typically work together, coordinating with one another to strengthen whole structures of power. By this account, the privileged term in each binary reinforces the privileged terms in all of the supposedly foundational binaries; thus the rational, masculine, public subject governs the emotional, private, woman object: he is all mind, she body. And as these binaries align, the theory goes, they consolidate power and agency in the hands of white, male subjects.⁴

Many theorists in the humanities since the first wave of poststructuralism have sought to disrupt these painful hierarchical binaries by revealing their instability and conventionality, the necessary contamination of the first, foundational term by the second, abjected one, and hence the impossibility of policing the boundary between the two. Judith Butler, among the most influential of these theorists, writes:

Gender is the mechanism by which notions of masculine and feminine are produced and naturalized, but gender might very well be the apparatus by which such terms are deconstructed and denaturalized. Indeed, it may be that the very apparatus that seeks to install the norm also works to undermine that installation, that the installation is, as it were, definitionally incomplete. . . . Whether one refers to “gender trouble” or “gender blending,” “transgender” or “cross-gender,” one is already suggesting that gender has a way of moving beyond that naturalized binary.⁵

Gender, as “mechanism” and “apparatus,” is no fact of nature, but an instrument or device that produces hierarchical distinctions. And in generating distinctions it also affords the possibility of undoing them.

Such deconstructive approaches to binaries are now so familiar in literary and cultural studies that they have themselves become something like

second nature in the field. While I have learned a great deal from this rich theoretical literature and will draw on it here, I will also depart from it in three specific ways. First of all, I want to separate the form of the binary from the form of the hierarchy. Poststructuralist theory has alerted us to the troubling fact that seemingly neutral binaries can hide hierarchies, but that does not mean that the two forms are always the same. Binary forms divide a field of objects, bodies, or ideas into two domains. The use of two refrigerator compartments, one for vegetables and the other for fruits, imposes a binary—a perfectly humdrum one—that does not mask a worrying hierarchy. Astronomers have identified seventeen pairs of stars that operate as nonhierarchical binaries, a small minority of star systems, but an intriguing phenomenon nonetheless.⁶ While it may not be particularly interesting to discuss nonhierarchical binaries in literary and cultural studies, because these are precisely the ones that have few troubling implications, a rigorous formalism keeps these two forms separate for analytical purposes, the better to grasp what each affords and how each works. If it is true that binaries do not always coincide with hierarchies, it is a formalist method that will help us to understand when and how the two forms converge and reinforce one another's organizing power.

While some binaries are not hierarchies, it is also true that some hierarchies are not binaries. My second departure from the poststructuralist approach entails an attention to the sheer variety of hierarchical structures that organize us. Compare the gender binary, a simple structure, to the organizational hierarchy of a transnational corporation, for example. Or consider racism, which both splits the world into a simple binary—white and nonwhite—and also frequently functions as a spectrum, where gradations of skin color organize power and privilege within each category. Class, too, typically takes the shape of a composite, multilayered hierarchical structure. In Europe in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, the scale moves up from the lowest ranks of beggars and indigents to factory and farm workers, soldiers, artisans, and petit bourgeois shopkeepers, to bankers, military officers, large landowners, and upper nobility. Within the aristocracy and the military are many minute gradations. To be sure, one could characterize class in terms of simple binaries—bourgeoisie and proletariat, haves and have-nots—but Marx himself was interested in distinguishing levels within these categories, separating the urban proletariat from the rural peasantry and the *Lumpenproletariat*, that ragtag group that allied itself with the monarchy and financial sector in 1848, and so became a major obstacle to working-class revolution.⁷ All hierarchies afford gradation, in other words, and their numerous ways of structuring inequality invite a formalist's close consideration.

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My third and most important departure from deconstructive methods builds on the first two: as many different hierarchies simultaneously seek to impose their orders on us, they do not always align, and when they do collide, they are capable of generating more disorder than order. This argument will be familiar from other chapters, but it is most surprising when it comes to hierarchies, since these seem like the most straightforward manifestations of brute power. In fact, as they collide with other hierarchies and an array of other forms in social situations, hierarchies often go awry or are rerouted, and they can activate surprising and sometimes even progressive effects. The most strategic approach to the power exerted by hierarchies, then, is not always to dismantle, flatten, or upend them. If we start instead by observing hierarchical forms to see what arrangements they impose and to consider what happens to their organizing power when they intersect with other forms, we can find new ways of disturbing their power. It is the intersections of hierarchies with other forms and the intriguing, often unanticipated consequences that follow that will form the main focus of this chapter.

Social scientists have recently articulated a similar starting-point, arguing that hierarchies turn out to be surprisingly fragile, unpredictable, and vulnerable to breakdown. International relations theorist Alexander Cooley writes: “We have been taught . . . that hierarchical polities are relatively functional, ordered, and well-governed entities.” But as a result, scholars have failed to notice “the types of control losses and authority slippages in hierarchical organizations and [to ask] why the mere imposition of hierarchical governance does not always lead to the outcomes predicted by a dominant power.” The reason we do not pay attention to these slippages, Cooley argues, is that we put too much emphasis on ideology and identity at the expense of understanding the complex work of “organizational forms.”⁸

This chapter will develop Cooley’s claim, arguing that if we consider closely the workings of hierarchical forms, we will find that they exert a far less orderly and systematic kind of domination than we might expect. I begin with a reading of Sophocles’s *Antigone*. In this tragedy, the playwright sets a number powerful hierarchies in motion, almost all of them organized as simple binaries: masculine over feminine, king over subjects, friends over enemies, gods over humans. As these meet and intersect in the course of the dramatic action, a firm insistence on one hierarchy typically ends up reversing or subverting the logic of another, generating a political landscape of radical instability and unpredictability. *Antigone* has had of course an enormous influence on Western philosophy, and in some ways I approach it here more like a philosopher than a conventional literary critic, considering

not the play's generic conventions and artful language but rather the relations of power and value that it presents, explores, and questions. But I do not, like many philosophers, conclude by siding with one character over another—Antigone or Creon, for example—or by trying to stake a position that fuses or critiques the implicit values that the tragedy stages. I make the case instead that Sophocles is unusually interested in the ways that dominant terms of hierarchical binaries fail to align and coordinate, and indeed relentlessly get in each other's way, leading to outcomes that elude the intentions of even the most powerful characters. In this way, Sophocles offers a robust answer to Elizabeth Grosz and other theorists who have focused their closest attention on cases where binary structures reinforce one another. Reading this tragedy as a plausible thought experiment, I suggest that Sophocles unfolds a persuasive but unfamiliar account of power, as he carefully works out the repercussions of multiple overlapping hierarchical binaries operating at once.

Sophocles, then, invites us to imagine that hierarchies interfere with one another's capacity to organize the world. The second section of this chapter expands to include other forms: what happens when bounded wholes and rhythms, too, come into the picture, organizing our experience atop or alongside hierarchies? Do these different, nonhomologous forms work with or athwart one another? My main focus here will be gender norms, a problem of longstanding interest in literary and cultural studies, and one we have already encountered in this book. Gender operates as a particularly stark form, a blunt binary that imposes its order not only on bodies, but also on other social forms, such as public and private spaces, divisions of labor, styles of dress and speech, and authority. While Butler is right to point to "cross-gender" and "transgender" as challenges to the binary, we can see how even these terms recognize the boundary line that constitutes the form of gender in the first place. The simplicity of the gender binary makes it an especially portable form, one that organizes materials and values both ancient and modern, across periods and continents.

For Sophocles, gender appears as a binary opposition that divides into higher and lower categories, but in *Antigone* it becomes complex and interesting when it runs up against other very similar binary forms. And indeed, although gender is simple in itself, organizing many realms of experience according to its straightforwardly oppositional logic, the formal story grows knotty and strange because the gender binary crosses paths so consistently with *other* forms—wholes, rhythms, and other hierarchies. As these many overlaps occur, the form of gender ends up producing ideologically strange effects. At times, as we will see, it can even come into conflict with *itself*.

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The first two parts of this chapter focus on hierarchies that are also binaries. In the third part of the chapter, I will turn to a far more complex formal pattern: the bureaucratic hierarchy, that quintessentially modern management ladder, with its pecking order of subordinates and superiors. What form does an organizational hierarchy take, and can it impose a clear order on workers and the processes of their labor? Drawing from scholarship in the sociology of organizations, I argue that bureaucratic forms frequently clash and collide with each other, the management hierarchy overlapping with multiple tempos, bounded spaces, and other hierarchies, including—to come full circle—the hierarchical binary of gender.

A formalist analysis of hierarchy has two implications for literary and cultural studies. First, this approach points us to an unfamiliar analysis of power relations, offering a critique of prevailing assumptions about the political contexts of cultural production and reception. Second, as I will argue in the concluding section of this chapter, hierarchies matter to the act of reading, the vertical form of the hierarchy shaping our daily interpretive practices. In fact, I will make the case that political readings of texts both generalize forms and rank them. I turn here to Bruce Robbins, who suggests that hierarchies structure even the most politically progressive writing in literary studies, including postcolonial, Marxist, and feminist criticism. The goal, familiar now from previous chapters, is not always to find a way beyond hierarchies, but to figure out how to work productively with them.

Antigone

Written in fifth-century BCE Athens, *Antigone* has fascinated philosophers and political thinkers into our own time. Deliberately disobeying the formal edicts of the state in favor of ancient customs that honor family ties, Antigone herself has been taken to stand for a variety of values and positions, including a violent legal order that predates the state, the struggle between ethics and politics, mourning, femininity, monstrosity, civil disobedience, and the queering of kinship. Hegel, Schelling, Kierkegaard, Lacan, de Beauvoir, Irigaray, Derrida, Žižek, and Butler are among the many thinkers who have understood the drama as posing crucial questions about proper and improper relations among self, kin, and state. Hegel, most famously of all, argued that the play revolved around a collision between a nonpolitical, feminine devotion to a particular family and a masculine, universalizing commitment to the public good in the form of the state.⁹ Two principles, familial piety and citizenship, each vie for ascendancy over the other.

And yet, to reduce the play to *two* principles does not quite do it justice. The king, Creon, insists on the superiority of masculinity and upholds the power of the state over kinship, enforcing the legal division between insiders and outsiders as he does so. Antigone, by contrast, sets her loyalty to ancient gods over state power, asserting her feminine right to disobey the state publicly in the name of a familial love that she argues should take precedence over the law. Both claim to hold the good of the people higher than their own private interests. In other words, Sophocles gives us not two but at least six major organizing principles: public and private, gods and humans, king and people, man and woman, obedience and disobedience, and friend and enemy. All of the characters understand these binaries as hierarchies, with one term in the pair higher than the other.

From the very beginning, both major and minor characters struggle to make choices in the face of these contending hierarchies. In the first scene, Antigone tells her sister Ismene that Creon, the new king of Thebes, has denied their brother Polyneices a customary burial, which, she says, dishonors the laws of the gods. When Antigone urges Ismene to help her bury Polyneices, to honor the sacred ties of kinship rather than the king's unjust orders, her sister is horrified:

[T]hink how we will die, most miserably of all, if in defiance of the law we transgress the power of the king. We must remember that we were born women, not to fight against men. . . . I, at least, will beg those beneath the ground to forgive me, since I am coerced in this; I will obey those who are in power.¹⁰

Ismene invokes two hierarchical binaries—king and subjects, and men and women. Antigone insists that a third—gods and humans—trumps the other two: “I will please those below longer than those here, for there I will lie forever” (7). While Antigone puts her love for her brother and the eternal power of the gods above the earthly power of the state, Ismene reaches for the hierarchy of gender to argue that the gods may forgive women who have been coerced into passivity by more powerful men. Antigone then rejects her sister, invoking a fourth hierarchy—that between friends and enemies—and casts her sister on the side of the enemies: “[Y]ou will earn my hatred” (9), she says, condemning Ismene for choosing the king over her own family.

This last hierarchy is in fact the one that launched the action of the play in the first place. Polyneices, fighting his brother for authority over Thebes, has married a foreign wife who has helped him to raise an army. Creon

denies Polyneices a burial precisely on the grounds that he has been an enemy, not a friend, to Thebes.¹¹

These forms may seem to organize the antagonisms in *Antigone*, but they also immediately disorganize them. Antigone is moved by loyalty to the private sphere of the family over the public domain of the state, and she insists that this loyalty is so good and so precious that there can be no shame in it, so she speaks out publicly against the king. In the process, she becomes a public spokesperson for the preeminence of the private sphere. And in speaking out publicly, she violates norms of femininity and becomes masculine in Creon's eyes, an act which in turn threatens to feminize him. "She boasts and laughs at what she has done," he complains. "Surely I am not the man now—she is!—if victory goes to her without punishment" (37). All along, Antigone's defiance rests partly on her sense that she is speaking publicly for the people of Thebes, acting in solidarity with the collective, and indeed she accuses Creon of putting his own private desires before those of the state—precisely what he has accused her of doing.

These kinds of ironic reversals recur throughout the play. Antigone, who has decided that Ismene is an enemy of the family, refuses to accept her sister's plea for solidarity, though it is precisely her insistence on the solidarity of the family that has led Antigone to reject Ismene in the first place. Antigone's supposed dedication to "the pure form of siblinghood," as Stefani Engelstein has argued, actually becomes "the elevation of one sibling above another, of Polyneices over Ismene."¹² Butler writes of her own surprise at finding how thoroughly the text's famous binaries falter and collapse: "how [Antigone's] actions compel others to regard her as 'manly' and thus cast doubt on the way kinship might underwrite gender, how her language most closely approximates Creon's, the language of sovereign authority and action, and how Creon himself assumes his sovereignty only by virtue of the kinship line that enables that succession, how he becomes, finally, unmanned by Antigone's defiance, and finally by his own actions, at once abrogating the norms that secure his place in kinship and in sovereignty" (6).

Butler and others have taken these ironies as inspiration to pursue a deconstructive style of argument, and to show how what are asserted as foundational rules and norms, such as stable kinship norms, turn out to depend on deviations and transgressions—their "constitutive outside." My own approach is complementary, in the sense that it too points us to a recognition that binaries necessarily waver and fail, and it too refuses to posit any single law or concept as foundational. But methodologically, the formalist approach I propose here is quite different.

I begin by understanding each form to have its own logic, its own principle of imposing order. Thus the opposition between friends and enemies offers a marked and distinct hierarchy, one that legitimizes war and violent punishments enacted by the state against criminals. Similar in form, gender operates as a binary division, the masculine predominating over the feminine. The opposition between the public realm of the collective and the private realm of the family and that between gods and humans also work by dividing the field of experience into two unequal parts. But these various binaries, though formally alike, do not map perfectly onto one another: an enemy may be feminine or masculine; a citizen who is loyal to the gods may be disloyal to the state; and a king who serves his own people may be dishonoring the gods.

The next step for the formalist reader, then, is to consider what happens to these hierarchies when they run into one another. The dramatic action of the play can be traced to a series of moments when characters choose one hierarchy over another: Antigone is obedient to the gods and disobedient to the state. She upholds one hierarchy (gods, humans) and so violates another (king, subjects). But in the process she happens to bring other hierarchies into play: she begins as feminine (lower) and an enemy of the state (lower) who favors the particular ties of kinship (lower), but by speaking out against the king becomes a public actor (higher), who is loyal to the gods (higher) who are on the side of the people (higher). Which means that her single choice of one hierarchy over another manages to transform a whole series of others, as low (woman, family, enemy of the state) becomes high (on the side of the Theban people and the gods), while high (man, state, public) is cast low (enemy of the gods and the people). The monarchy itself can grow tangled in its own binary forms: the state exerts laws that supersede any loyalty to kin, but it is the logic of kinship that controls the line of succession and assigns the head of state in the first place.

Antigone's choice of one hierarchy over another both inverts the usual order and blurs and disorders other hierarchies. For example, in choosing not to hide her choice of the gods over human laws, Antigone becomes public and so crosses the gender binary, suddenly appearing manly. She also undoes two other hierarchies, turning private loyalty into a public act, and in honoring the brother who was an enemy of the people, makes herself their friend. In the process, she manages to fracture even the organic form of the individual: she sets herself against herself (in the sense that she is willing to die to preserve her well-being) and sets Creon against Creon (in the sense that his commitment to the state undoes his commitment to the state). By choosing one hierarchy that happens to violate another hierarchy,

then, Antigone becomes at once high and low, masculine and feminine, public and private, friend and enemy to the Theban people, self and not-self. Her end in this context is perfectly appropriate to her radically unsettled status: she is both killed and left to die, both entombed and alive.

Two minor characters in the play, less defiant than Antigone, try to work within the hierarchical structures that organize experience, but they find that it is impossible to harmonize them all. Haemon, Creon's son and Antigone's betrothed, struggles to be loyal to all of the contending parties: his father, his wife to be, the gods, the state, *and* the family. Pleading absolute friendship to his father and the state, he warns the king to honor the gods by forgiving his future wife. That is, he believes that he is being loyal to the king-state-father and tries to protect these higher terms in three hierarchies from the harm that will come from punishing an enemy of the state because she is also the friend of the gods and of Haemon himself. If it were true in this case, as it is often claimed, that hierarchies align in Western culture to produce powerful ideological and cultural formations, Haemon would not run into trouble. But he does. Creon, who had argued at first that the gods were on the side of the state, now, in his struggle against Antigone, assumes that Haemon's invocation of the gods must put his son on the side of the enemy. The friend-enemy hierarchy dominates Creon's logic so powerfully that he willingly sets himself against all allies of Antigone, including the gods and his own son, condemning him as the "slave of a woman!" (55)—lower than the low. Far from consolidating powerful hierarchies and showing how well they work in concert, Sophocles's representation of Haemon suggests that it is literally impossible to uphold the father, the gods, the king, masculinity, and the state all at once.

Meanwhile, Ismene too attempts simply to be loyal. Her fear for her sister's well-being marks her, from Antigone's perspective, as a cowardly friend to the state and traitor to the family, while from Creon's vantage point she appears loyal to her family and disloyal to the state. Ismene's single-minded attachment to the person of her sister, in other words, marks her confusingly as both public and private, both friend and enemy, because Antigone's actions have already blurred the division between the two spheres.

In a world in which binaries are so snarled together that they are constantly transforming one, it becomes impossible to choose a single hierarchy to organize the world. The hierarchies break down not because they are internally contradictory but because their encounters with other hierarchies unsettle them. Antigone's defiant speech and actions weaken Creon, raising her and lowering him. Since he insists that men are superior to women, the fact that she bests him, in his logic, makes her manly. In theory, the logic

could just as easily go the other way: according to patriarchal reasoning, one could argue that her words are meaningless because they issue from the mouth of a woman, and women do not and cannot speak publicly. The space of formal collisions is in this sense an aleatory one—unpredictable even as each form tries to preserve its own logic—because it is not clear at any moment which form organizes all the others.

To be sure, one could argue that the whole Sophoclean system rests on an ultimate hierarchical binary: gods and humans. In the end, the drama punishes Creon for his hubris. But the gods' role in relation to the other hierarchies in the drama remains thoroughly indeterminate. The characters raise the question of whether the gods will side with ancient kinship customs or with the state—it could go either way. Creon insists that the gods will reward anyone who dedicates himself to the good of the *polis*: “Can you see the gods honouring evil men? Impossible!” (23). The friend of the state will be the friend of the gods. But Antigone is convinced that the gods will appreciate those who honor their laws over those of human beings: the friend of the gods can be an enemy of the state. Even the chorus changes its mind about the relation between humans and gods. Given the play's punishment of all concerned—Polyneices, Antigone, Creon, Haemon, Ismene, Eurydice, and all of Thebes, which is “sick” by the end of the drama—it is not clear that any position can lay claim to being on the side of the gods. Tragedy, famously, does not set wrong against right, but right against right. The gods are on all sides, and on none.

What Sophocles offers us, then, is a conflict among contending forms that disorders their logic without ever resettling them or simply inverting them. Nor does he imply that any single hierarchy grounds or organizes all of the others, offering a desirable or stable form for the future. The play's promiscuous punishing suggests, moreover, that the implications of the struggles between forms cannot be contained: the consequences of colliding hierarchies go everywhere. Ismene, trying simply to preserve her sister, and Haemon, trying to serve traditional hierarchies, are both victims of the unsettled order, caught up in the logic of contending forms. Antigone's initial choice throws persons, intentions, and all kinds of hierarchical ordering principles into disarray, as a woman becomes masculine, private turns public, a king becomes “less than nothing,” and a single-minded devotion to the good of the *polis* ends up sickening the city.

The play is a valuable thought experiment for the formalist method I propose here, because it asks what consequences are likely to ensue when the binary forms that structure political experience come into conflict. My reading does not rely on traditional literary formalist methods, which

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would focus on the ways in which rhythm, metaphor, and dramatic structure come together in a taut unity. But it would also be a mistake to claim that literary form does not matter at all to this reading. I have privileged one form over others—dramatic narrative form, or the conflictual unfolding of events from an initial decision. In asking what might plausibly follow from a complex starting circumstance, Sophocles puts forward a set of ideas about how forms work. Thus a time-bound literary form allows us to think through the social work of nonliterary forms, as they carry their affordances with them into the tragedy.

Most philosophers and political theorists approach *Antigone* as a way to consider ethical or political choices and their consequences: should one choose kinship ties or state laws, the particularity of the brother or the generality of the *polis*? The form of tragedy would seem to be ideally suited to such philosophical questions: resting on a conflict between genuine alternatives, rather than vilifying or idealizing one position or another, tragedy asks how we might come to terms with opposing notions of the good.¹³ Both a conventional philosophical reading and my own formalist one move easily between the forms of the drama and the forms of the world. And what is crucial to note here is that even highly political interpretations, ones that are more or less uninterested in the aesthetic, *use* the form of the drama to help to shape their own theories of the world. It is impossible to think ethics or politics outside of discursive forms such as argumentation, description, and presentation. Dramatic form affords some kinds of political and philosophical thinking that are foreclosed by other forms. *Antigone* is valuable, then, not only as an autotelic artwork, beautifully crafted as a totality—though it is certainly that—but also as a formal model for political relationships, one that restructures our attention and invites us to think anew about the power of hierarchies to organize our world.

Gender

Gender emerges as one of several powerful hierarchical binaries in *Antigone*, one that can be upended and reversed in relation to other hierarchies. Now I want to extend this claim, moving beyond a formal model in which multiple hierarchies collide, to consider a set of circumstances in which other kinds of forms, too, work with and against gender norms. In the last two chapters, we have seen wholes unsettling other wholes and rhythms colliding with rhythms, but in the world it is not only similar forms that meet. The rest of this book will consider how unlike forms encounter one another: what happens, for instance, when an event or experience is being organized

simultaneously by rhythms, wholes, and hierarchies? As in Sophoclean tragedy, these formal collisions can produce strange and aleatory possibilities. Gender is a good place to start, because, as we will see, it regularly forces hierarchies into relation with numerous other forms and shows how hierarchical power can be destabilized in these encounters.

Although literary and cultural studies scholars do not typically refer to gender as a form, theorists such as Foucault and Butler have given us strong reason to do so. These thinkers have argued persuasively that gender does not emerge out of given or prior sex distinctions, but is repeatedly asserted and reasserted through attention to norms and deviations. Gender's "apparatus" entails the policing, the enforcement, of its binary structure. Thus any body, any practice, any genre or style could be gendered masculine or feminine, or some combination of the two, and penalized from moving out of its proper sphere.¹⁴ To put this another way: the masculine-feminine binary is an organizing rule, an abstract, generalizable principle that can impose order here and there, on a multiplicity of social materials. Like enclosures and rhythms, it is capable of being repeated across time and space. This is by no means to claim that these forms are universal, or that they transcend particularity to give us access to some deep truth or value. But we have learned from decades of feminist scholarship that the gender binary does not belong to a single culture or context. And just about anywhere it goes, gender is an organizing principle by which social groups come to be organized in a hierarchy, one high and one low, one wielding power and the other coerced into service. Thus it makes sense to think of gender as one of many iterable structures or patterns that are constantly shaping experience. It is more like a literary form than a fact of nature, a made or crafted shaping of materials.

This understanding of gender as a simple form might seem to go against scholarship in the past few decades, which has emphasized its complexity and multiplicity.¹⁵ Intersectional analysis made the case that gender structures social experience only in the context of other vectors of oppression and discrimination, such as race, class, sexuality, and disability.¹⁶ Rejecting simplistic accounts of gender, scholars of the nineteenth-century United States have gone so far as to reject the category of "separate spheres" altogether. As Cathy Davidson explains, the gender binary "is simply too crude an instrument—too rigid and totalizing—for understanding the different, complicated ways that nineteenth-century American society or literary production functioned." She claims that it is a convenient "metaphor" that allows contemporary scholars to think simplistically about nineteenth-century culture. And so she calls for its dismissal.¹⁷

Davidson is right to be concerned that the gender binary is too simple, too orderly, too all-encompassing to describe the complexities of nineteenth-century social life. And yet I would argue that this is not in itself a reason to stop thinking about gender in binary terms. What if the binary is crude but also sometimes operative? What if gender functions *as* a binary, and sometimes powerfully? After all, it may be precisely because identity categories are characteristically simple that they can spread and be generalized. As Jane Gallop puts it, “with most of the workings of gender and/or authority, the crude and schematic is usually all too apt.”¹⁸ The gender binary has force, in short, *because* it is reductive.

Simplicity is not itself a reason to cast gender off as an analytical category. But Davidson’s worry that the gender binary leads to a reductive account of socio-political and cultural experience has force. It is my contention that the problem is not that gender itself is simplistic, but that it is too clear-cut if we consider it in isolation. If we look for the ways in which gender divides the social world in two, it will appear that it imposes its uncomplicated order on social materials. But part of what makes social experience complex is the fact that the gender binary is always working with and against other identity categories, such as race, class, and sexuality. And not only other identities: gender also encounters other forms—forms of knowledge, forms of narrative, forms of subjectivity, space, administration, education, repetition, circulation, collectivity, worship, and intimacy, among many others.

Let us continue our look at gender, then, by investigating in more detail the very form rejected by recent Americanist scholars like Davidson—the “separate spheres” associated most closely with the nineteenth century. The metaphor of “separate spheres” suggests that the gender hierarchy overlaps with another form, a bounded whole, or to be precise, two bounded wholes. One is the masculine, public realm of commerce and public life, the other the feminine, private sphere of home and family. “Separate spheres” evokes not only a clear binary, then, but also two spatially delineable forms. And although this is often only a figure, the idea of separate spheres for masculine and feminine activity has certainly imposed its order on literal spatial arrangements, containing women within domestic walls, for example, and preventing them from speaking in political forums.¹⁹

Since spaces are often gendered, and since gender is conceptualized as a space, it is tempting to understand gender simply through the form of the spatial container. And yet, the gender binary also regulates temporal experience. Contemporary societies urge girls not to begin sexual activity too soon and not to postpone marriage too long, while expecting boys to separate from their mothers and seek autonomy earlier than their female

counterparts. Gender can also organize tempos of labor. Women around the world often undertake a “double workday,” performing paid labor as well as unpaid domestic work.²⁰ On nineteenth-century slave plantations in the United States, gender often organized both the workday and the lifecycle, as older women looked after infants so that their mothers could labor through the daylight hours. And gender can also impose its order on definitions of maturity. For centuries in Europe, young boys grew out of dresses and gowns and into trousers, a custom known as “breeching.” And after WWI, the British Parliament passed a law allowing women who were householders to vote, but they had to be over 30, while men could begin to vote at 21.

If the gender binary operates *across* both bounded spaces and temporal rhythms, we need to think the relations among three different forms: first, the hierarchical form of gender arranges social materials into two levels of power and authority, with the masculine occupying the higher rank and the feminine the lower. This hierarchy then also divides sociocultural spaces into separate containers coded masculine and feminine, and it imposes its order on time as well, generating rhythms marked as masculine and feminine. While containers organize space and rhythms regulate time, hierarchy is the form that creates domination and oppression, producing the most painful material effects. Politically, then, we might well assume that hierarchy is the form of social organization that matters most.

But when forms overlap and collide, hierarchy does not always dominate the formal field. Let me offer an example from nineteenth-century Britain. I draw here from Teresa Mangum’s intriguing work on aging. As Victorian men grew old, Mangum tells us, they outlived their active roles as agents in the public realm. The aging nineteenth-century British male faced “if not an outright loss of sexual identity then a lapse into a state akin to helpless femininity.” Images of older men often figured them as feeble, useless, and pitiable, their alignment with femininity entailing a painful loss of personhood. But not always: “this feminization . . . sometimes signals moral, spiritual and domestic fulfillment. The tolerance for a gentler, more maternal masculinity in old age helps to explain the appeal of characters like Dickens’s reformed Scrooge in *A Christmas Carol* (1843) [or] Job Legh (who is single-handedly raising his granddaughter) in Gaskell’s *Mary Barton* (1848).”²¹

In short, the temporal rhythm of the masculine lifespan, characterized by the familiar ages of man—infancy, childhood, youth, maturity, and old age—overlapped with the spatial containments organizing the masculine public and feminine private spheres and produced uncertain effects for gender identity and masculine privilege. Did the domestic sphere appreciate

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in value when the old man came to inhabit it, or did his relegation to the feminine sphere of the home render him comparatively worthless? Was he masculine or feminine, contemptible or admirable, emptied of authority or filled with care? Or to ask this another way: when hierarchy encounters rhythm and bounded whole, is it possible to predict which will organize experience? Will the higher term in the hierarchy retain its status despite the depredations of time and the containment of domestic space, even raising the domestic to a new height, or will the rhythm of aging and the confinement to the home succeed in bringing the man down in the social hierarchy to the feminine side of the gender binary?

The aleatory paths of colliding gendered forms are not limited to the Victorian context. Recent economists and sociologists note an ongoing transnational phenomenon they call the “family gap” in wages: men with children earn more than men without, and they are held to a substantially lower standard at work than non-fathers, while precisely the reverse is true for women.²² Given traditions of discrimination against women in the workplace, it is not surprising to hear that mothers earn less than childless women, but why are men with children rewarded over those without? On the one hand, sociologists contend that the powerful stereotype of the male breadwinner continues to account for the pay differential, but they also note that fathers are allowed to take more time off work than their childless counterparts and are rewarded for doing so, suggesting some social returns for fathers who adopt a domestic role.²³ In this example, rather than lowering men in the social hierarchy, paternal care and responsibility for children literally raises the value of the domestic sphere.

In other cases, the opposite may result: when men become full-time homemakers, their association with conventionally feminine domesticity may diminish their status.²⁴ Together, what these examples suggest is that the relations among bounded wholes, rhythms, and hierarchy are unstable because their collisions genuinely afford multiple outcomes. And what this means is that hierarchy does not always organize political life: it can be disturbed and rerouted by forms as various as the arc of aging and domestic space.

Bureaucracy

Up to this point, I have been working with hierarchical forms that take the shape of simple binaries: higher and lower. *Antigone* suggests that even simple, traditional binaries, when thrown together, can have uncertain and deforming effects. But in the past two centuries, a much more complex hierarchical form has become a common organizing experience globally:

the bureaucratic ladder. Max Weber famously described its multiple “levels of graded authority,” composing “a firmly ordered system of super- and subordination in which there is a supervision of the lower officers by the higher ones.”²⁵ This formal chain of command leads from the production line worker to the CEO, and from the bottom rung of the military or civil service to the highest-ranking official. It is the kind of pecking order that organizes labor unions, colonial administration, church leadership, political parties, universities, government agencies, and corporations—public and private, official and unofficial, left and right, national and transnational. It is also one of the most widely reviled of social forms, though in contradictory ways, as it stands simultaneously for “bungling inefficiency and threatening power”: “Incompetence, red tape and feather-bedding on the one side; manipulation, obstructionism and Byzantine intrigue on the other.”²⁶

With their endless rules and record-keeping, bureaucracies seem to drown us in mere formalities—procedures sustained for the sake of procedure itself. Yet, at the same time, these records do keep track of our bodies, our medical and psychological health, our education, our credit ratings, our citizenship, creating a storehouse of knowledge that can be used for or against us. These bureaucratic records, with their combined connotations of uselessness and power, have given us one of the most common contemporary meanings of the word *form*: the endless forms—tax forms, immigration forms, registration forms, evaluation forms—that monitor individuals whose lives come into contact with modern institutions. This meaning of *form* strangely haunts—and is haunted by—its aesthetic other. That is, bureaucracies come under attack for being self-perpetuating, for producing endless red tape, until it seems as if the business of bureaucracies is to create pure formalities, their forms meaningless—*pro forma*. But this, in turn, suggests an understanding of bureaucracies as autotelic bodies—self-contained and autonomous, referring only to themselves. We are not far, it seems, from the perfection of Immanuel Kant’s aesthetics, which casts art as an end in itself, both useless and powerful.

This understanding of bureaucracy as dedicated entirely to serving its own ends is certainly what infuriates Dickens in his scathing portrait of government in *Little Dorrit*, where the Circumlocution Office sends Arthur Clennam back and forth between departments with the express purpose of frustrating business of any kind. One official obligingly tells him: “I can give you plenty of forms to fill up. Lots of ’em here. You can have a dozen if you like. But you’ll never go on with it.”²⁷ The law receives similar treatment in *Bleak House*. When the case of Jarndyce and Jarndyce finally comes to an end, the result is enormous waste in the form of “great bundles of paper”:

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“bundles in bags, bundles too large to be got into any bags, immense masses of papers of all shapes and no shapes, which the bearers staggered under, and threw down for the time being, anyhow, on the Hall pavement, while they went back to bring out more.”²⁸ Dickens popularizes an understanding of bureaucracies as inward-looking and self-perpetuating.

The hierarchy of the bureaucratic world in Dickens is especially maddening. After one employee in the Circumlocution Office offers a particularly convoluted set of instructions to Arthur Clennam, we learn that this official “fully understood the Department to be a politico diplomatico hocus pocus piece of machinery, for the assistance of nobs in keeping off the snobs. This dashing young Barnacle, in a word, was likely to become a statesman, and to make a figure” (119–20). It is precisely his understanding of bureaucracy as purposeless that will help young Barnacle to climb its ladder and achieve his own purposes. According to Dickens, then, self-serving individuals devote themselves to advancing in the hierarchy, and as they do so the hierarchy itself dominates to the exclusion of other values, forms, and purposes. Thus bureaucracy becomes *pro forma* indeed—existing solely to perpetuate its own hierarchical structure.

Of course there is another and even grimmer side to bureaucracies. Dostoevsky, Kafka, Orwell, and such films as *Ikuru* and *Brazil* show them as nightmarish in their capacity to control our lives. Unappreciated workers perform meaningless work, governed by the inexplicable decisions of faceless managers in distant, high-level departments. *The Adjustment Bureau*, a 2011 film, imagines a secret bureaucracy, topped by a shadowy figure called the Chairman, that determines the life of every living person according to “the plan.”

Both the self-perpetuating and the threatening power of bureaucratic organizations crop up often in the popular imagination: from police procedures to newspaper accounts to fiction. These representations of criminal, welfare, immigration, psychiatric, and credit organizations, with their forms and records, workers and managers, repeatedly remind us that such organizations produce serious material effects, determining everything from health and unemployment benefits to prison terms and deportation.

I have listed here just a few examples among many, simply to suggest that bureaucracy plays an important role in modern understandings of power. What many thinkers from Dickens and Weber onward have shared is a sense that it is dominated by a single form—the hierarchy—that subordinates us all to its maddening ladder-like logic. Those at the top of a bureaucracy issue give unaccountable commands; those lower down take orders while seeking to rise; outsiders are mystified, frustrated, and disempowered. But

it is the main argument of this book that to isolate a single form and to assume its dominance is almost always an act of oversimplification. Something much more complex, formally speaking, happens in the day-to-day operations of bureaucracies.

I want to suggest that a formalist approach invites a more productive understanding than Dickens or Orwell of the intricacies of bureaucratic power. To grasp the overlapping of multiple forms in the workings of bureaucratic organizations, I turn here to the work of Robert Jackall, a sociologist who studied a large US corporation in the early 1980s. One aspect of the organization he noticed was that it was structured by two different management hierarchies: line and staff. Those on the line were the workers and managers actively involved in production; staff were those who acted in an advisory capacity, offering technical or organizational expertise, environmental oversight, or legal guidance. The two sets of managers, Jackall found, were locked in a constant competition:

The more freedom staff have to intervene in the line . . . the more they are feared and resented by line management. For line managers, independent staff represent either an unwelcome “rules and procedures mentality” into situations where line managers feel they have to be alert to the exigencies of the market, or, alternatively, as power threats to vested interests backed by some authority. In the “decentralized” organizations prevalent today in the corporate world, however, most staff are entirely dependent on the line and must market their technical, legal, or organizational skills to line managers exactly as an outside firm must do. The continual necessity for staff to sell their technical expertise helps keep them in check since line managers, pleading budgetary stringency or any number of other acceptable rationales, can thwart or ignore proffered assistance.²⁹

At any given time, either of the management hierarchies could be “higher” than the other. As the hierarchies encountered one another, the managers regularly came into conflict over the rules and procedures that governed everyday operations. And this ongoing tension was not the only power struggle shaping the organization’s day-to-day work. This corporation, like many others, was divided into specialized units including production, sales, marketing, and finance. Although ultimately they were all supposed to be contributing to a larger whole, in fact these units were constantly “at cross-purposes,” vying with one another for authority (37). Meanwhile, some managers made alliances and built “fealty relationships” that cut across rival

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hierarchies and allowed them to negotiate backroom deals. Often these alliances were more important than profits and losses: “You can lose money and still be an insider; you can make money and still be an outsider,” one manager explained (66). The hierarchies were also regularly turned upside down, as managers’ success turned out to be dependent on the accomplishments of their underlings (46).

In short, far from being structured as the single ladder described by Weber’s “firmly ordered system of super- and sub-ordination, in which there is a supervision of the lower officers by the higher ones,” the bureaucracy as it appears in Jackall pits multiple hierarchies against one another, encourages alliances that traverse competing divisions and hierarchies, and holds managers accountable for the work done by their subordinates. All of this contributes to an environment of perpetual uncertainty: it is rarely clear who is rising and how, which unit commands the most respect and resources, and whether line or staff will at any moment get the upper hand. Not surprisingly, then, no single strategy will guarantee advancement: neither capitulation to norms, teamwork, deception, clandestine negotiation, displays of creativity, socializing with the right people, nor cutthroat competitiveness. Any one of these may work at one moment and fail at another.

The resulting anxiety fosters an intense focus on the workings of the hierarchy itself, as managers become consumed with ascending the corporation’s ladder. In this sense, Jackall agrees with Dickens: bureaucratic hierarchies foster an obsession with advancement at the expense of other values and purposes. For Jackall, climbing high in the corporation requires a high tolerance for moral ambiguity, a willingness to take advantage of others’ misfortunes, and “the brazen nerve that allows one to pretend that there is nothing wrong even when the world is crumbling” (219). But Jackall is more precise than Dickens in his analysis of the forms that produce this damaging ethos. For Dickens, bureaucracy’s structures and rules are so mad-deningly complex as to be altogether irrelevant—not worth representing—with the exception of the ladder to be climbed, which motivates ambitious bureaucrats. Jackall, by contrast, is meticulous in his attention to the pecking orders, units, and alliances that together, in complex and unpredictable collisions, produce opportunities for advancement and stagnation, integrity and corruption.

While Jackall’s study only reinforces the familiar sense that reforms are likely to be frustrated and ethically minded workers likely to languish or fail altogether, his work does unsettle two conventional assumptions about the power of hierarchical forms. First, he exposes the multiple hierarchies that struggle against one another even within a single organization, while

they also run up against alternative forms—alliances, networks, and coteries. To speak of “the career ladder” is therefore to simplify a formal landscape composed of multiple vertical and horizontal forms constantly intersecting, disrupting, and rerouting one another. If Weber’s bureaucrat is a “discretionless single cog in an ever-moving mechanism which prescribes to him an essentially fixed route of march,”³⁰ Jackall’s bureaucrat has more agency (in the sense that she can choose a coterie over a hierarchy if she likes), less control (in the sense that she cannot work with the grain of all of the many forms that crisscross the organization), and less direction (in the sense that she has to make a difficult choice between making a deal with a manager in a different department or focusing instead on pleasing her immediate superior).

The second contribution Jackall makes is to show that bureaucracies are not so self-enclosed—so autotelic—as we are in the habit of imagining. Multiple forms, sometimes even shaped by more than one hierarchy, will structure any given organization, and since organizations typically interact, each hierarchy will work in a context where many forms are operating. In *The External Control of Organizations*, Jeffrey Pfeffer and Gerald R. Salancik show how complex these interacting forms can be: “Organizations are linked to environments by federations, associations, customer-supplier relationships, competitive relationships and a socio-legal apparatus defining and controlling the limits of these relationships. . . . This is true whether we are talking about public organizations, private organizations, small or large organizations, or organizations which are bureaucratic or organic.”³¹ Ecological rather than autotelic, a bureaucracy cannot revolve solely around its own self-serving purposes, and all bureaucrats have to look not only up but also around, considering external pressures and forms beyond the ladder.

For example, one company Jackall studied experienced a large environmental disaster in the late 1970s. After substantial public outcry, the management instituted serious reforms to prevent a future incident. But just a few years later, during an economic downturn, “Brown,” the company head, decided to lay off the environmental staff.

Brown himself said at a managerial meeting that good staff simply create work to justify their own existence. Many line managers echoed this opinion. More to the point, the feeling was that work on environmental issues had lost any urgency in the Reagan era. The Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) was dead. Moreover, the only real threat to corporations on environmental issues was in the courts, which, however, judge

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past actions, not present practices. By the time the courts get to cases generated by contemporary practices, typically in fifteen years, those executives presently in charge will have moved on, leaving any problems their policies might create to others. (33)

Brown makes his decision at the crossroads of three different bureaucracies—his own company, a regulatory agency, and the courts. In this example, he takes advantage of their conflicting forms to make a terrifying choice. Seeking to please the CEO, he sets about trimming the company budget. In the competition between the line managers and their staff counterparts, he chooses the more efficient line. To justify this choice he turns to another hierarchy—the relationship between the executive branch of government and a regulatory agency. The new president, he thinks, will bring down the agency, a move legitimated by a popular opinion that is swinging in an antiregulatory direction. The only other body that might shape the corporation is the judiciary, and here Brown cannily, if immorally, sets two temporal forms side by side, arguing that the courts, given the slow rhythm at which they operate, will not be able to act in time to disturb the quick tempo of corporate leadership. Given three different bureaucracies and three contending forms—at least two hierarchical structures and a pair of rhythms—he concludes that he can make the expedient decision to lay off his environmental staff.

Brown finds room for agency amid pressures from competing forms—his position in a management hierarchy, the constraints of environmental regulatory rules, a new presidency, the tide of public opinion, and the courts—deliberately setting their forms against one another in an effort to make the decision that will best serve his company's interests, and his own. Ironically, this decision gets Brown demoted, plunging him down the hierarchy of the very company he has so carefully sought to serve. Not unlike Creon's fate, Brown's freedom to act amid contending hierarchies brings about his own demise. A kind of hubris, in both cases, allows these leaders to imagine that competing forms can be fully understood and harnessed to their own ends. To be sure, the story does not always end tragically for corporate protagonists. Jackall, at the end of his book, notes that a few at the top are highly rewarded for "the ability to read the inner logic of events, to see and do what has to be done" (219). But along the way he also observes that some who do not understand the "inner logic" rise, while others who read it well fall. The contingency of colliding forms—in a world structured by numerous nonhomologous rhythms, shapes, and hierarchies—can derail even the most ruthlessly strategic striver after success.

So much, then, for understanding colliding forms. It does not guarantee a climb up the corporate ladder. But my goal here is different from Mr. Brown's. I want to understand the workings of forms in ways that do justice to their capacity for disorganization as well as for organization, and from that starting-point to consider what an effective politics might look like. If hierarchies do not always organize other forms—if they can be disrupted by containers, rhythms, and other hierarchies—then authority may well prove surprisingly fragile. And at the very least, exerting power is no simple matter of the position one holds in a hierarchy, and we cannot assume that certain actors will always organize the social world successfully to their own ends. Amid the complex and aleatory overlapping of social forms, there are always opportunities for unexpected and ideologically unsettling outcomes.

Gender, Bureaucracy

So: what happens when the two major hierarchical forms we have analyzed so far—gender and bureaucracy—encounter one another? We might assume that we know the story all too well: glass ceilings limit the capacity of women to ascend, and any job that becomes too closely associated with women loses status, causing wages to sink. But even here the collision of the two hierarchies can produce some deforming and unpredictable effects. In an influential feminist study, Rosabeth Moss Kanter did research on the first women sales-workers and managers in a US corporation in the 1970s. She was particularly interested in what happened in a “skewed” workforce, where there was a large majority of a single group, which she calls the “dominants,” and a small minority of another, the “tokens.”

The preponderance of male workers at the higher levels of Kanter's corporation had everything to do with the continuing power of separate spheres. Professional women who had risen in the corporation were rare, because bourgeois women were expected to stay at home, in the private sphere. But their rarity in the office had a paradoxical effect: the fact that there were so few women made each highly visible, constantly noticed, gossiped about, and evaluated. They became inescapably “public creatures,” as Kanter puts it.³² The very binary form that marked women as private thus *also* produced their fate as public characters. This reversal then forced the women “tokens” to exaggerate their public side:

Many of the tokens seemed to have developed a capacity often observed among marginal or subordinate peoples: to project a public persona that hid inner feelings. Although some junior management men at Indisco,

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including several fast trackers, were quite open about their lack of commitment to the company and dissatisfaction with aspects of its style, the women felt they could not afford to voice any negative sentiments. They played by a different set of rules, one that maintained the split between public persona and private self. (385)

Women—traditionally the bearers of the internal (emotion, the home, the private)—had to suppress inner feelings to become insiders in the public world outside of the home, while masculine insiders, traditionally bearers of the external (reason, the workplace, the public), could afford to express their inner feelings because they were so firmly on the inside of the outside.

If a token woman in the bureaucratic hierarchy could unsettle the logic of separate spheres, Kanter considered what happened when offices hired two women, rather than a single token. She tracked three different scenarios. In the first:

One woman was characteristically set up as superior, the other as inferior—exaggerating traits in both cases. One was identified as the success, the other as the failure. The one given the success label felt relieved to be included and praised, recognizing that alliance with the identified failure would jeopardize her acceptance. The consequence, in one office, was that the identified success stayed away from the other woman and did not give her any help with her performance, withholding criticism she had heard that might have been useful, and the second woman soon left. (394)

Here, the men in the office split the two women apart by forming a new hierarchy. One woman became doubly subordinate—lower than all the men and then cast further down below her sole female counterpart, who was complicit in the hierarchy between women because it seemed to draw attention away from her role in the hierarchy between men and women, despite the fact that it was the male-female hierarchy that had created her anxious and subordinate status in the first place.

In the second case, the male coworkers treated the women as “an automatic pair,” dividing the workplace into masculine and feminine domains, and seeing themselves as “relieved of the responsibility for interacting with or supporting the women.” Turning to the logic of the bounded whole, the men opted to separate the workplace into clearly delineated spheres, and in this case their formal choice reinforced the gender hierarchy. The women treated in this way were often alarmed by being forced

into isolation together and so sometimes turned against one another, “trying to create difference and distance between them and becoming extremely competitive” (394).

The third situation Kanter describes emerged when the two women developed an alliance,

and refused to be turned against each other. Strong identification with the feminist cause or with other women was behind such alliances. Allied, two tokens could reduce some of the pressures and avoid some of the traps in their position. They could share the burden of representing womankind, and they could each be active on some pieces of “the woman’s slot” while leaving time free to demonstrate other abilities and interests. (394)

By understanding themselves structurally, as part of a subordinated group in a large-scale gender hierarchy, pairs of women could create and sustain their own antihierarchical form: an alliance of equals. This alliance then helped them to counter the typical problems of tokenism, reducing their sense of isolation and vulnerability to criticism. Peer partnership became literally an emancipatory form, freeing up time for women to do something other than play strictly gendered roles. Freedom thus meant not an escape from all constraints, but a strategic deployment of the form of the allied pair.

Based on this study, Kanter called for an increase in the proportion of minority workers to “dominants.” Her research has since been contested, with other scholars arguing that numbers alone cannot counter discrimination, since a larger proportion of a minority group in the workplace can provoke backlash, actually increasing sexual harassment, wage disparities, and the insistence on glass ceilings.³³ But Kanter’s work remains compelling as a formalist study of power. It shows that when hierarchies collide, they re-route and deform as much as they organize, unsettling divisions between public and private and masculine and feminine. Her study also makes clear that the structure of the pair, when it interacts with the other hierarchies in play—the career ladder, the gender binary—carries unpredictable effects with the potential to produce new hierarchies, competitions, *or* alliances.

Contending Hierarchies

In these corporate examples, as in my reading of Sophocles, I have asked what outcomes can plausibly or predictably ensue when hierarchies

encounter other forms as well as each other. The results are more aleatory than conventional accounts of power usually suggest: the binary form of gender sorts masculine from feminine in ways that powerfully subordinate, yes, but that also strain and unsettle the logic of other binaries, creating openings for the inversion, breakdown, and transformation of public and private, feeling and reason, friend and enemy, power and powerlessness. But so far, the vast majority of our colliding hierarchies have ended tragically, and our only happy outcome has emerged from a rejection of hierarchy altogether in favor of egalitarian alliance. While I wholeheartedly embrace equality as a formal alternative to hierarchy, I want to conclude by suggesting that hierarchies themselves can overlap and clash to surprisingly productive and emancipatory effect, producing political opportunities as well as tragic endings.

In this conclusion, I am drawing on the work of Bruce Robbins, who makes a fascinating point about overlapping hierarchies in his 2007 book, *Upward Mobility and the Common Good*. Here he argues that upward mobility stories are not exactly, or only, narratives in which impoverished or marginalized characters betray their roots to climb a class ladder at the expense of those they leave behind. Rather, they are stories that “by focusing on the passage *between* identities and how one gets from here to there . . . reveal something important about power.”³⁴ To be precise, these narratives reveal the processes of mediation by which particular characters rise in the social hierarchy. Whether depending on loving individual benefactors or social institutions, protagonists who climb the social ladder recognize not their own capacity for self-making but their interdependence, and this recognition, Robbins argues, fosters a desire for the kind of social mediation best enacted by the welfare state.

At the end of the book, Robbins disagrees with Gayatri Spivak’s influential reading of *Jane Eyre*, departing from her especially strongly when it comes to how hierarchies work. Spivak makes the case that the dark-skinned, Caribbean-born Bertha must fall so that Jane may rise. It is Bertha’s exclusion that allows Jane to take her place at the center of the social world, as a legitimate insider. The narrative thus sacrifices the Third World woman for the sake of the First World protagonist.³⁵ Since Spivak, many other critics have returned to *Jane Eyre* to consider the text’s support for racist and imperialist ideologies.³⁶ But Robbins offers a different response. Rather than conceding that Jane’s success depends on Bertha’s rejection and expulsion, he suggests that we need to disaggregate two hierarchies: class on the one hand and the global center/periphery—or First World/Third world—divide on the other. Spivak, he writes,

seems unwilling to admit . . . that if the international division of labor takes some political representativeness away from the working-class European, it also *bestows* some political representativeness upon the middle-class non-European. It is only the core/periphery disparity dictated by the international division of labor that gives the middle-class postcolonial any right at all to speak for fellow nationals, a right that a more orthodox Marxism, seeing in such a figure only another member of the bourgeoisie, would deny her. This is a large point. . . . It suggests the possibility that upward mobility stories may not after all be built on the absolute necessity of betraying and sacrificing some Bertha Mason or some representative of Third World indigeneity. (239)

To put this another way, both Spivak and traditional Marxism have fused together two hierarchical forms, bourgeoisie/proletariat and center/periphery, assuming that they work together in a coordinated way. Robbins urges us to separate them, and argues that something important happens at the point where they cross: the middle-class person from the global South can become a center-periphery mediator, a “First World/Third World go-between” (242). It is at the junction of two overlapping hierarchies that Spivak herself can become a mediating figure, taking advantage of her class status and professional success to act as a powerfully critical voice on behalf of the Third World. That is, Spivak’s power is itself an effect of two forms, two hierarchies, as class meets the First World/Third World divide.

Robbins’s broadest argument rests on the presumption that there is no need to assume that one person’s rise necessarily comes at the expense of another. A missionary’s efforts at conversion, a woman’s chance at meaningful social action, a professor’s opportunity to shape students and public debate, the work of the welfare state to provide an opportunity to leave poverty behind: all of these mediating acts seek to raise certain people in the social hierarchy, but they are not all dictated or dominated by a single master-hierarchy: European imperialism or bourgeois power. To the contrary, one hierarchy might unsettle another, as Spivak herself seeks to do when she takes advantage of her class status and professional success to speak as a critical voice on behalf of women in the Third World. And in the end, Robbins suggests that we teachers surely know this already. We try to help our students rise not, typically, in order to make them superior to others, but to teach them the critical skills and knowledge that make for responsible citizenship, which will, in turn, help to raise everyone else. That is, we struggle to be mediators of social mobility for the common good.

My own goal, here, is to contribute to Robbins's persuasive argument by articulating the formal logic that underlies his claims. To assume that a European woman's meaningful career necessarily comes at the expense of an indigenous other, or that a man's choice of the domestic sphere will always come at the expense of his power, is to assume a master-hierarchy of values that works like a zero-sum game: a gain in one place always entails losses elsewhere. And this is simply not how hierarchies—or indeed forms in general—work. They are just as likely to unsettle one another, their collisions as liable to produce gains in odd places as to reinforce given structures of power. Robbins is right to reject the zero-sum game, that is, because no single hierarchy governs all others, nor do they all work together, successfully reinforcing Western imperialism, or the ruling class, or patriarchy. In fact, where two powerful hierarchies cross—bourgeoisie/proletariat and center/periphery—we find one of academia's most influential voices speaking on behalf of the global South.

At one intriguing moment, Robbins considers the crossing of two other hierarchies that have concerned us in this chapter: gender and professional advancement. Reading *Jane Eyre*, he urges us to think about St John's invitation to bring Jane to India as opening up the imaginative possibility of an alternative ending: "He offers her . . . what she is ready to consider meaningful and desirable work—work whose desirability for Jane comes in part from the fact that it might not *require* marriage, the fact that it replaces marriage with otherwise unavailable possibilities for personal autonomy and socially significant action" (64). Robbins insists that the text "registers this disruptive energy" even while it does not fulfill this narrative possibility (65). Not dissimilarly, Deirdre David sees Jane as the prototype for a colonial administrator, recasting the ambition and dedication that St John admires in her as well suited to the bureaucratic ladder that will soon be in place. It is in fact only St John's insistence on the strict superiority and power of the husband within marriage that precludes this outcome for Jane. Thus St John's gender hierarchy is all that forecloses a totally different kind of future: an ending that promises not the hierarchical divisions of gender but the equally hierarchical pleasures of ambition, climbing the ladder in the service of a meaningful career.

Despite their shared interest in an implied alternative ending in which *Jane Eyre* rejects marriage for work, Robbins and David introduce different hierarchies as they spin out their implied narratives. For Robbins, St John's proposal allows Jane and the reader to imagine a life of relative autonomy, where work ranks above marriage; while for David, Jane's prospective career might grant her freedom and autonomy, but only at the expense of

colonized peoples. What most differentiates the two readings is a decision about where the story of hierarchical forms stops: Robbins stops sooner than David, with one hierarchy, the choice of work and autonomy; David's narrative lasts longer, imagining that Jane's choice would support a new hierarchy.

Is this what critics do? Do we spin out implied stories in which new forms take shape beyond a narrative's end? This probably does not sound like our usual account of literary reading, but I want to suggest, in closing, that most politically minded critics do precisely this. They attend to the political forms within the text in order to generalize them beyond the text's own example, extending the political ordering principles that are at work in the text to understand its implied rules for ordering the extratextual world. It is the portability of political form that permits these readings to happen at all, and it is our own ideas about how these forms operate in the world that guide or govern our assessment of the politics of literary texts. This means that acts of political reading routinely rely on implicit models of the plausible unfolding of forms.

Let us stick with *Jane Eyre* for the moment. Critics have never come to a consensus about the narrative's conclusion. For some readers, Jane's willingness to rank erotic love above a life of painful service is liberatory, while for others her choice to sink into domestic oblivion, contrasted with St John's heroic ending, is a disappointment.³⁷ Some readers have embraced Jane's assertion of the "here and now" as part of the secularizing project of the realist novel, while others have celebrated her resistance to St John as an alternative spiritual mission that entails a new and radical Christian feminism.³⁸

What is happening here, I want to suggest, is not so much divergent *interpretations* of the text as an array of competing hierarchies on the part of both the text and its readers. There are two major sources of dispute among critics. The first emerges from the fact that this is a novel that offers real irresolution around some of its own hierarchies of value: while the text is perfectly clear about some of its hierarchies—such as the superiority of Britishness and the usefulness of a colonizing mission—it is unwilling to rank, clearly and finally, the relative merits of individual autonomy, erotic passion, ambition, the pleasures of home, respectable marriage, meaningful work, and religious service. In fact it is by offering a number of unresolved hierarchies that the novel unleashes the "disruptive energy" that it does not ultimately settle into any fixed or conclusive relation. It is this irresolution that allows us readers to spin out multiple implied social worlds.

The second source of dispute stems from the critics' own differences over values: Does a woman's insistence on erotic pleasure in a patriarchal

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context have more or less significance than her embrace of a domestic sphere over ambition and broader social action? Does Jane's ranking of earthly pleasures over otherworldly rewards matter more or less than her language of spiritual mission and her willingness to give the last word to the text's missionary? It might well make sense for us to debate those questions apart from literary texts, since these are questions that are less about Charlotte Brontë than about our own hierarchies of value.

In the end, the methodological point is not to decide, once and for all, on a particular text's hierarchy of values, or on our own, but to become clear-eyed about the ways that the vertical form of the hierarchy structures acts of literary reading. As we struggle to reveal the text's distinctions of privilege and priority, we also grapple with ethical, political, and professional hierarchies that organize nontextual worlds. Do we rank the human costs of imperialism far higher than a middle-class female character's opportunity for career advancement? Can hierarchies of value coexist? What happens when they operate together? If a new formalism has one lesson to offer, it is this: a close analysis of contending and colliding hierarchies invites us to rethink effective political action.

NETWORK

Sprawling and spreading, networks might seem altogether formless, perhaps even the antithesis of form. For some influential theorists, in fact, it is their resistance to form that makes networks emancipatory—politically productive. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari famously offer up the rhizome as a network that connects any point to any other, and argue for it as a disorganizing, destabilizing answer to the more conventional unifying form of the tree, with its binary branches that all reach back to a common root, fixing a single order. “Nothing is beautiful or loving or political aside from underground stems and aerial roots,” they write.¹ Ella Shohat claims, too, that the ever-spreading reach of networks is politically valuable: only networked flows and circulations will allow us “to transcend some of the politically debilitating effects of disciplinary and community boundaries.”² In this tradition, networks usefully confound containing forms.

Many literary and cultural critics have grown interested in networks in the past decade, using the concept to describe powerful social facts, such as transnational markets, transportation, and print culture. Most have defined networks loosely and generally as “connectivity.”³ Recently, however, as network theory has emerged across disciplines, humanists, including Patrick Jagoda, Patrick Joyce, and Franco Moretti, have begun to turn to studies of networks in mathematics, physics, and sociology to show how these connective configurations follow knowable rules and patterns. While it is certainly true that networks do not fit formal models of unified shape or wholeness,⁴ even apparently chaotic networks depend on surprisingly systematic ordering principles, “the most famous one being the so-called ‘small-world’ property, or ‘six degrees of separation’: the uncanny rapidity with which one can reach any vertex in the network from any other vertex.”⁵ Critics have started to think through Mark Granovetter’s influential thesis about the “strength of weak ties”—the notion that people one knows only slightly can bring one access to a wider range of information and resources than those in one’s close-knit circle, who, precisely because of their intimacy, share overlapping knowledge and contacts.⁶ Cultural studies has

also started to import such terms as *path length*, which counts the number of links that separate nodes; *network centrality*, which analyzes the popularity and importance of a node to the whole network; *hubs*, objects or persons that play a role in more than one cluster of nodes; and *hinges*, nodes that connect otherwise separate groups.⁷

This new vocabulary suggests that we can understand networks as distinct forms—as defined patterns of interconnection and exchange that organize social and aesthetic experience. Though they are not self-enclosed totalities, networks have structural properties that can be analyzed in formal terms. And an attention to the patterns governing networks will allow us to think in newly rigorous ways about political power and social experience.

In previous chapters, I have considered what happens when just two or three forms meet: when national boundaries meet narrative closure, or when the gender hierarchy encounters the arc of aging and the enclosures of domestic space. As a form that first and foremost affords connectedness, the network provides a way to understand how many other formal elements—including wholes, rhythms, and hierarchies—link up in larger formations. Specifically, network organization allows us to consider how many formal elements connect to create nations or cultures. It is thus a form absolutely crucial to our grasp of significant assemblages—including society itself.

Networks are useful, Bruno Latour suggests, because they allow us to refuse metaphysical assumptions about causality in favor of observing linkages between objects, bodies, and discourses. Latour asks us simply to notice points of contact between actors as well as the routes actors take.⁸ By tracing the actual and possible paths that forms follow, we can practice a large-scale cultural studies method that starts not by presuming causality, but rather by attending to specific patterns of contact between forms. What connects different forms? What routes do they take once they have encountered one another?

The term *network* derives from the language of metallurgy and textiles used in the sixteenth century to describe objects made out of fabric or metal fibers interlaced as in a net or web. Something like *text*, the roots of the term imply interwoven strands moving in multiple directions rather than directed toward a single end.⁹ The concept of the network has since expanded to include animal and plant tissues, natural crystalline structures, and, since the nineteenth century, social relationships—including any string or structure of interconnections, from transportation and communication systems to property, business, professional associations, and even literature itself.¹⁰ Defined in the most straightforward way, a network is “a set of connections

that link [discrete] elements.”¹¹ The identity of those elements and the particular ways in which they connect can vary vastly, from computers to organic tissue to city planning to friendships.

Literary and cultural studies scholars who have been interested in networks have typically focused on one at a time: the slave trade, the print marketplace, the telegraph, global capital. Jonathan Grossman’s fascinating new *Charles Dickens’s Networks* singles out transportation networks from others—including communications, politics, religion, and economics—in order to “sharpen” our understanding of the specificity of passenger transport.¹² Even Manuel Castells, one of the most influential theorists of the complexity of our globally networked society, imagines a remarkably streamlined and coherent single kind of network at the heart of it all: “Technology *is* society.”¹³

To be sure, it is clarifying and practical to isolate a single network and pursue its impact, since when networks are thrown together they can seem messy or incoherent. But it is also misleading to treat them as separate. I draw here on the work of sociologist Michael Mann, who has argued, unlike Castells, that “[o]verlapping interaction networks are the historical norm.” Mann makes the case that networks are not the effects of modernity, technological innovation, or globalization. In ancient empires, for example, “the mass of the people participated overwhelmingly in small-scale local interaction networks yet were also involved in two other networks, provided by the erratic powers of a distant state, and the rather more consistent, but still shallow, power of semiautonomous local notables.” It is the rule, not the exception, to be enmeshed at one and the same time in economic exchanges, legal systems, military alliances, churches, communications, transportation, and linguistic meanings, all “powerful, sociospatially different networks.”¹⁴

A formalist approach advocates paying careful attention to the multiplicity of networks and especially to their differences. Some networks are densely local, such as social relationships in a village; others, like shipping routes, put vast spaces between nodes. Some are centralized, like the Catholic Church; others have multiple hubs, like air transportation. Some are utopian, transnational, and discursive, such as Leela Gandhi’s “affective communities”;¹⁵ others, like the federal prison system, are material and coercive. Some, such as global finance, are complex, linking numerous institutions, people, and places; others are simple—two children communicating across a wire tied between tin cans. Some cross boundaries more readily than others: religious communities can cross oceans; railroads cannot. All networks afford connectivity; all create links between disconnected nodes.

Politically, they are neither consistently emancipatory—freeing us from a fixed or dominant order—nor always threatening—trouncing sovereignty or dissolving protective boundaries. Their power to organize depends on the particular patterns of each network and the ways that its arrangements collide with other networks and other forms.

I will begin this chapter with an investigation of encounters between unified wholes and networked connections, a set of relations that, I will argue, has been absolutely fundamental to cultural studies, from early twentieth-century anthropology to recent scholarship on global flows. Our understanding of cultures has itself depended on a shifting and largely unarticulated set of assumptions about what happens when these two forms are overlaid. Some theorists, like Shohat, have assumed that circulatory flows, transnational migration, and economic exchanges are always and necessarily opposed to wholes and enclosures, including cultural and national boundaries, while others have imagined that they work together, reinforcing one another's power. Turning to a formalist analysis, I will ask how specifically these forms clash and collide, and if and when they are capable of working in concert.

I will then turn to the overlapping of multiple networks, which is a far more ordinary fact of social life—and a more unsettled and unsettling one—than literary and cultural studies has recognized. Here I develop my own understanding of networked form through two readings, one nonfiction and the other fiction. The former is Trish Loughran's study of print culture in early America, *The Republic in Print*, which makes the case that multiple, overlapping networks—mail, print, money, and roads—interrupted each other and frustrated the work of consolidating a new nation. The second is Charles Dickens's *Bleak House*, a novel that casts social relations as a complex heaping of networks that not only stretch across space but also unfold over time. Attentive to multiple principles of interconnection as they spread and overlap, Dickens uses narrative form to convey society itself as a network of dynamically unfolding networks.

Network, Whole

Implicitly as well as explicitly, cultural studies has been fascinated by networks for a long time. Early twentieth-century anthropologists understood cultures in terms of harmonious relations between the whole and the network. That is, they saw any given culture as a coherent network of meanings, practices, and values that allowed one to grasp the wholeness of a particular way of life. For Franz Boas, Bronislaw Malinowski, and others, cultures were

not just an accumulation of details that happen to be observable in a particular place but rather “the wholes in which everything is somehow related to everything else,” the “network underlying or permeating or hovering above surface phenomena.”¹⁶ Cultural studies continues to invoke this notion of culture, according to James Buzard, even as it has come under strong critique by anthropologists.¹⁷

We can see one clear example in the work of Catherine Gallagher and Stephen Greenblatt, who claim in *Practicing New Historicism* that they are fascinated “with the possibility of treating all of the written and visual traces of a particular culture as a mutually intelligible network of signs.”¹⁸ Referring to “the invisible cohesion” of “the cultural matrix,” they imagine cultures as composed of networks that flow within the boundaries of a knowable whole:

We are intensely interested in tracking the social energies that circulate very broadly through a culture, flowing back and forth between margins and center, passing from zones designated as art to zones apparently indifferent or hostile to art, pressing up from below to transform exalted spheres and down from on high to colonize the low. . . . [This approach grows out of] a fascination with the entire range of diverse expressions by which a culture makes itself manifest. (13)

That “a culture” should have a “center” and an “entire range of diverse expressions” implies a wholeness, a unity; that it is crisscrossed by “social energies” that “circulate” and “flow” suggests that there can be no apprehension of culture without networked movement. The “culture” that is the focus of historicist cultural studies emerges here as precisely a harmonious cooperation of network and whole.

Recent critical work suggests that this New Historicist model of culture is now obsolete. First of all, anthropologists have come to agree that there is no such thing as a self-enclosed culture—certainly never one that can appear as such. In James Clifford’s classic argument, we rely on observers and informants, mobile points of contact between cultures, to gain access to the most isolated of villages. Traditional anthropology typically effaced the means by which the ethnographer came and went from the site, “the boat, the land rover, the mission airplane,” any of which were evidence of “systematic prior and ongoing contacts and commerce with exterior places and forces which are not part of the field.” Clifford notes, too, that many kinds of things pass through remote sites: armies, tourists, television, objects for sale.¹⁹ People and goods leave and return.

Attention to economic, transportation, and communication networks has therefore been crucial to undermining the ideal of authentic, isolated, self-contained cultures. Recent studies of migration and diaspora, transnational trade routes, contact zones, and traveling cultures have focused on the network's capacity to trouble or crack open bounded totalities.²⁰ And as scholars have paid an increasing attention to networks, they have tended to refuse the harmonious overlaying of wholes and networks in favor of a conflictual relation. Some critics consider wholeness to be a myth that networks helpfully shatter. Others adopt wholeness as a troubling reality that can and should be violated by networked extension. And still others want to hold onto the older form of the rooted community as a safeguard against global capital and the homogenization of linguistic and cultural experience worldwide.²¹ In all of these cases, critics insist that networks breach the form of the bounded whole.

And yet, what both earlier and later conceptualizations of culture share is an implicit reliance on these two major forms to grasp cultural experience: it is the relation of networks and wholes that allows us to grasp culture as an object of study. For Boas, Gallagher, and Greenblatt, it is the wholeness of a culture that allows its network of crisscrossing connections to become perceptible in the first place, and they see boundaries as capable of containing networks. For most theorists of globalization and cultural encounter, on the other hand, including Shohat and Clifford, networks are the forms that rupture or defy enclosed totalities and allow us to understand border-crossing circulations and transmissions.

So: which is it? Are networks containable or uncontainable by bounded shapes? I want to suggest that a formalist approach is exactly what we need to answer this question—an attention to specific encounters between bounded wholes and network sprawl. Theoretically, networks are capable of unending expansion: once there is a link between two nodes, there is a network, and it can grow simply by linking to new nodes. Thus the network form affords a certain infinite extensiveness. But in practice, many networks are limited. Some operate as deliberately closed systems, such as Local Area Networks (LANs), which link a finite number of computers. And even networks that do expand can be governed by strict rules: a kinship network makes potentially endless new links by marriage, reproduction, and adoption, but all of these are controlled by the state, religious institutions, and custom, which routinely set powerful constraints on which particular nodes may link to each network. It is true that some networks can cross and even undermine the boundaries of containing shapes. Indeed, it is networks of this kind that most often make their way into popular culture: multinational

capital, disease, terrorist networks, and the world wide web, which violate national boundaries in frightening ways. But these do not represent all networks. Consider, for example, transportation systems—roads, railroads, canals. These are expandable in theory, but each addition requires infrastructural investment, and sometimes complex international treaties. Roads and railroads cannot cross large bodies of water, and some objects and bodies are not permitted to cross national borders, even when the means of access exist. Expansions are often abandoned or delayed. In short, some networks cannot cross boundaries at all, and many do not cross easily.

And so, when it comes to the relationship between wholes and networks, it is not always clear which form will dominate. Some networks can be contained; others thwart containment. Global capital itself actually requires both networked sprawl and containing boundaries. Multinational corporations, always on the lookout for favorable economic conditions around the world, have the power to move from place to place, frequently displacing local economies and shaping the political agendas of individual nation-states as they demand land, access, and special tax provisions. In this respect the global flow of capital challenges the sovereignty of the nation-state. But states, for their part, continue to keep strict control on the mobility of workers across national borders, and enforce laws that protect corporate property—both boundaries that are crucial to the success of multinational enterprises.²² When we consider terrorist networks, the picture becomes more complex still. Often operating outside of the logic of the nation-state, terrorists have inspired nations to build ever-higher walls and other barriers to try to exclude or contain them. Thus national boundaries continue to operate powerfully—and sometimes more powerfully than ever—in the face of transnational networks.²³

In recent years we have been inclined to assume that networks always violate the bounded enclosures that either imprison or protect us. But let me offer a last example—a much more conventionally literary one—of a mutually sustaining encounter between a bounded shape and a sprawling network. This is the case of Emily Dickinson, who famously secluded herself in a bedroom in her father's house in Amherst, Massachusetts, and spent most of her adult life there, leaving the house only once, it was rumored, "to see a new church, when she crept out by night, & viewed it by moonlight."²⁴ Most critics, understanding the poet either as anxious and agoraphobic or as socially rebellious and independent, have emphasized the link between her physical enclosure and her intense interiority. But as Diana Fuss argues, this containing space also enabled a wide-ranging network:

The domain of privacy in which Dickinson is said to have been imprisoned or entombed actually offered the poet ample opportunity for intellectual growth; neither a space of confinement nor of death, Dickinson's bedroom proffered ready entry into the public world of letters. It is one of the great paradoxes of this poet's interior life that the more she withdrew, the wider her circle of acquaintances became. The Homestead bedroom was the place where Dickinson composed the vast majority of her seventeen hundred and seventy-five poems and an estimated ten thousand letters, of which more than a thousand survive. Here Dickinson communicated with her "private public," developing a public persona *as* a private poet.²⁵

Like the Wienhausen nuns we met in the first chapter, Dickinson was not controlled by a single form—feminine containment in one enclosed, private space—but by multiple forms, which overlapped to provide surprising opportunities. It is true that she retreated to the privacy of her bedroom, confined and immobile. But a network of letters and books passed through this room, as the networks of print circulation and the postal system enabled Dickinson to link herself to nodes near and far.

The poet's confinement actually freed her in crucial ways from social responsibilities and domestic duties. Her father's public stature as treasurer of Amherst College, a one-term congressman, and prominent local citizen meant that the house was "crowded daily with the members of this world, the high and the low," who exhausted the daughters of the house with their perpetual visits and requests.²⁶ When the family hired a servant and installed Franklin stoves, Fuss argues, Dickinson could retreat with relief from the demands of both household and visitors. Thus Dickinson's strategic embrace of a bounded enclosure allowed her to resist the draining networks of kinship and local society while permitting her to take part in a larger, more sprawling and energizing network: a transnational literary community.

Together, what these examples make clear is that networks and enclosures are constantly meeting, sometimes sustaining and reinforcing one another, at other times creating threats and obstacles. It shows that neither form has the final organizing word—neither always regulates the other. But that is not to say that we must throw up our hands in ignorance or apathy. What a formalist analysis affords is an interest in the specificity of each form—what kind of network is it? what rules govern it?—and a grasp of what the affordances of each network can entail for other forms. Which

networks can jeopardize, stabilize, or reroute bounded unities, and how exactly do they do so? Which enclosures successfully contain networks, and why? Rather than assuming that “culture” entails a neat containment of networks by shapes, or conversely, that networks always destroy or disregard boundaries, a formalist method offers the tools to track the particular range of ways in which these forms run up against each other and the consequences their encounters bring into the world.

Network, Network, Whole

Although literary critics have returned again and again to the relations between networks and bounded wholes, they have paid scant attention to the overlapping of multiple networks. In one notable exception, Trish Loughran offers a beautiful example of a society both organized and disorganized by a collision of different kinds of networks.²⁷ In fact, she invites us to think both about the relationships between overlapping networks and also about their impact on the wholeness of the nation, offering a critique of scholars such as Benedict Anderson and Michael Warner, who have assumed a causal link between the emergence of a communications network on the one hand and the formation of a shared national consciousness on the other. Instead of arguing that networks of print production give rise to a common and homogenizing attachment to the nation-state, Loughran shows how, in the United States, networks frustrated and obstructed the wholeness of the nation between the 1770s and the 1870s. Here, I will build on her work to underscore the formal terms of her argument and to suggest that her study offers a powerful example of the collision of networked and bounded forms.

Loughran begins by exploring the prerevolutionary postal system, which was supposed to unite the colonies. The British imposed a tax on all colonial mail, and in 1773, eager to collect on each item posted, they sent out an inspector named Hugh Finlay to figure out how to improve the efficiency of the system. What Finlay discovered, in terms I will borrow here from network theory, was neither a *centralized network*, where all paths successfully pointed back from the colonies to the Crown, nor a smoothly running *distributed network*, where all points could connect with one another, but rather a series of local *network clusters*, where the *hinges* between small groups of nodes were often missing or broken. Separated by bad weather, purposeful delays, and impassable roads, sometimes kept in a ruined state to frustrate rival colonies' trade (as happened between New Hampshire and Massachusetts), network clusters often failed to connect. Add to this that

colonial mail deliverers typically resented the British tax and frequently carried letters to friends and neighbors privately, and we can see that a tax-free, local network was superimposed on the centralized imperial network, whose hub was thousands of miles distant. As multiple networks operated in detached and overlapping forms, they thwarted both British rule and a coherently unified alternative.

A similar set of difficulties beset national print culture in the early Republic. Though the states were now better connected than they had been a decade earlier, in 1787, Loughran writes, “a functional market zone, or unified field of exchange, had still not materialized across the landmass of eastern North America. Indeed . . . there were few roads, no rails, and, in fact, very little money in the United States” (17). Without good hinges to connect scattered local networks both before and after the Revolution, there could be no centralized or powerfully influential national print culture—and consequently, Loughran concludes, no real sense of a shared national consciousness either:

[T]exts of this period leave a compelling record of the ways in which the potential unity of a still emerging American book market was routinely disrupted by material circumstances that were local in origin and localizing in effect—including, among others, geographic isolation, competing political affiliations, regional identification and diversity, and temporal lags in the production and dissemination of texts themselves. (22)

The problem was not that it was too hard to organize a network: it was that there were *too many* networks, each with its own logic, overlapping and running into one another—town, regional, print, and political networks, all working at once. Add to this a social rhythm that got in the way of national coherence—temporal lags in the circulation of print—and one begins to see why the nation could not cohere into a bounded whole. It failed to take a clear shape because there were simply too many organizing patterns at work, no one of them dominating or controlling the others.

Thus Benedict Anderson’s famous presumption that print culture can erase local difference in favor of “formal homogeneity,” Loughran argues, emerges in the early United States as nothing more than a fantasy.²⁸ One could certainly *imagine* the nation as a unity—understanding it in formal terms as a unified whole—but its multiple print, postal, economic, and regional networks, with their different organizing principles, broken links, and temporal delays, did more to hinder the nation from assuming a whole, unifying shape than to foster that reality.

Network, Whole, Narrative

I want to turn now to Charles Dickens's *Bleak House* (1854), another text that takes up the daunting challenge of understanding life in a world organized by multiple networks, and pushes this to a dramatic new level of complexity and nuance. As with *Antigone*, I am deliberately taking a fictional text as a model for understanding the social, an experiment in apprehending society through—and as—multiple contending forms. The point here is less to use formalist methods to read Dickens than to use Dickens to throw light on the operations of social form. If this seems like literary criticism turned upside-down, that is certainly part of my purpose. I have not understood literary texts in this book as reflections or expressions of prior social forms, but rather as sites, like social situations, where multiple forms cross and collide, inviting us to think in new ways about power. Some forms move surprisingly easily across social and literary contexts, and narratives are among the very best forms for identifying and tracking the unfolding of relations among different forms.

Bleak House is a highly unusual narrative in that it organizes experience around a heaping of separate but overlapping networks. Dickens, like Loughran, is interested in thinking through the relationship of sprawling networks to the bounded shape of a nation. But like Sophocles, he uses a specific literary form to make sense of these worrying social arrangements—in this case, the long narrative arc of the multiplot novel. *Bleak House* invites a careful analysis of the ways that the time-bound form of narrative collides with the overlaying of multiple networks. Network theorists in literary and cultural studies have rarely launched this kind of analysis. On the face of it, the networked crisscrossing among nodes in a system would seem to be best represented by synchronic forms, such as charts and maps. And although scientists and social scientists have recently begun to experiment with time-slicing to visualize networks unfolding, humanists interested in networks have almost always privileged space over time.²⁹ I argue here that Dickens makes brilliant use of the affordances of narrative form to conceptualize the ways that networks unfold temporally. This is a case where network theory and narrative theory can transform one another: networks expand and alter the usual conventions of narrative form, while narrative develops and challenges existing theories of networks and social power. By incorporating networks into the novel, *Bleak House* might seem to pave the way for recent “network narrative” films, as David Bordwell calls them, which are organized around political, technological, economic, and social networks, such as *Traffic*, *Syriana*, and *Babel*.³⁰ But I will

argue, here, that the nineteenth-century novel is more successful than these feature films at analyzing the complexity and power of networked social experience.

“Why, Esther,” says John Jarndyce, after Sir Leicester Dedlock has left the house, “our visitor and you are the last persons on earth I should have thought of connecting together!”³¹ *Bleak House*, deeply interested in the possibilities of interconnections between far-flung lives, joins haughty aristocrats to crossing sweepers and bricklayers, by way of philanthropists, soldiers, dancing masters, doctors, suitors, and lawyers.

But what exactly are the principles of interconnection in the novel? Rather than limiting what counts as a network interaction to actual words passed between characters, as Franco Moretti does, or restricting it to appearances in the same scene, as Jean-Baptiste Michel and others do, I want to follow Dickens’s lead in imagining the enormous variety of connectors that link people.³² The most obvious principle of interconnection in *Bleak House* is the lawsuit of Jarndyce and Jarndyce, which successfully keeps characters in the dark about their relations to each other, and certainly does not demand any face-to-face contact between them or their simultaneous presence on the scene. But the novel also imagines numerous other ways that characters are connected, some of which, like disease, depend on physical contact. As Jo passes smallpox to Esther, the contagion itself becomes a point of contact that links social actors across groups. The network of philanthropies is a third organizing principle, bringing Esther into contact with Caddy Jellyby and Mrs. Chadband into relation to Mr. Guppy. There is also the aristocratic social-political network, which links Lady Dedlock to the world of fashion and Sir Leicester Dedlock to parliamentary debates about social reform. And there is “rumor,” which “persists in flitting and chattering about town” (690). Crucially, the novel is interested in connecting patterns of kinship, the most important being the secret tie that links Sir Leicester Dedlock to Esther via Nemo and Lady Dedlock. The absence of face-to-face contact for many pages does not make this connection any less significant. Other organizing kinship networks are at work in the novel too, such as the one linking Trooper George to the Ironmaster and another that connects Mrs. Jellyby to Mr. Turveydrop. There is also the space of the city itself, which links characters like Charley and Gridley by mere proximity. “London.” is the famous first sentence of the novel, and the city can itself be understood as a network, a set of interconnected streets and buildings, linked largely by sheer contiguity. And because of the larger networks of transportation and communication that crisscross it, London is always linked to adjacent sites: its streets prove contiguous with rural roads, as Jenny and Liz show us when

they leave Tom-All-Alone's for Hertfordshire, where they will play a role in Lady's Dedlock's flight back into the city, the site of her death.

Importantly, too, the city does not work *only* as a principle of adjacency: it also fosters connections between characters and institutions. In one maddeningly complex example, Mr Bucket happens upon Jenny and Liz at Tom-All-Alone's while looking for Jo to identify the veiled lady at Tulkinghorn's chambers. Here the urban space of the city collects the rural bricklayers, who know Esther through Mrs Pardiggle of Jarndyce's philanthropic network; Jo, who holds the key to a set of mysteries about Nemo and Lady Dedlock, and whose poverty brings him to Tom-All-Alone's, which turns out to be part of the Jarndyce and Jarndyce suit; and Snagsby, Tulkinghorn, and Bucket, who are working to piece together the link between Lady Dedlock and Nemo. The city emerges in this example as a kind of meta-network, linking and assembling other principles of interconnection.

Now, one might argue that for Dickens all of these networks stop at the borders of the nation: *Bleak House* can absorb the landed aristocracy, the rural poor, and even the industrial north, but it explicitly and pointedly refuses to take in the Empire. And yet, the network's formal capacity for extension and contiguity pushes against even Dickens's deliberate nationalism. Despite Mrs. Jellyby's clear moral failure to concentrate her attention on national needs, Dickens finds himself strangely following her lead when, in one passage, he links Jo to networks that spread to distant places on the globe:

Jo comes out of Tom-all-Alone's, meeting the tardy morning which is always late in getting down there, and munches his dirty bit of bread as he comes along. His way lying through many streets, and the houses not yet being open, he sits down to breakfast on the door-step of the Society for the Propagation of the Gospel in Foreign Parts, and gives it a brush when he has finished, as an acknowledgment of the accommodation. He admires the size of the edifice, and wonders what it's all about. He has no idea, poor wretch, of the spiritual destitution of a coral reef in the Pacific, or what it costs to look up the precious souls among the coco-nuts and bread-fruit. (198–99)

Jo sits on a doorstep—an accident of the city as a network, since this specific doorstep just happens to be in close proximity to Jo when it is time for breakfast. But then the doorstep turns out to be itself a node linked to another set of nodes, since it adjoins a building that houses an institution that itself reaches out as far as a “coral reef in the Pacific,” sending books

and bodies around the world. The Gospel in Foreign Parts is uncannily like Dickens's own fiction, which would almost instantly reach India, Canada, Australia, and the United States thanks to networks of shipping, roads, railroads, print circulation, and colonial administration. Thus the nationalistic *Bleak House* reaches beyond national borders through networks both inside and outside of the text. Jo does not know anything about the connection between himself and "Foreign Parts," but this is no hindrance to the operation of a network; indeed, most of the characters in *Bleak House* are entirely unaware of their function as nodes in a dense overlapping of networks, but they are linked nonetheless to far-flung strangers in remote places through multiple webs of interconnection.

How could they be aware of them all? At one and the same time, characters in the novel are linked through the law, disease, economics, class, gossip, the family tree, city streets, rural roads, and even global print and philanthropic networks. Let me pause for a moment to note the strangeness of this list, its puzzling incoherence: some of these links are voluntary, others coercive; some follow the procedures of state institutions, others thrive on sheer proximity. Some—like the law and class relations—are hierarchical, while others—like rumor and urban space—can be fluid and egalitarian.

Each character acts as a node in at least one distributed network, in which any point can connect to any other without needing to go through any central site or in any fixed order, but what makes this novel so interesting and so complex is that almost all of the characters act as nodes in *more than one* different distributed network at a time. These networks are both separate and overlapping: each has its own logic, its own way of organizing and linking the social world, but each is also capable of connecting the same groups of characters as the others. Crucially, too, these principles of interconnection are not homologous, and in fact actually have the potential to derail and subvert one another. When Esther catches Jo's smallpox, she worries that she has become unmarriageable—unable to take her place as a new node in a kinship network. Mrs. Rouncewell commits herself willingly to serving an aristocratic hierarchy; and yet her position in a kinship system links her to the bourgeois Ironmaster, who is bent on replacing aristocratic power with capitalism, and to Trooper George, her favorite son, for whom she is ultimately willing to sacrifice the Dedlock family name.

In order to capture these many contending networks, Dickens expands the usual affordances of the novel. Depending on how you count them, between fifty and seventy characters populate *Bleak House*. To investigate far-reaching and overlapping networks—disease, urban streets, global philanthropy, the lawsuit, and so on—the novel needs to present lots and

lots of nodes, and to link them along multiple pathways. Such layered interconnection would simply not be possible with the ordinary number of novelistic characters: Jane Austen's three or four families, for example, or the marriageable woman caught between two suitors in the marriage plot. And so Dickens dramatically expands the conventional affordances of the novel by multiplying the usual number of characters.

Bleak House then uses networks to reconceptualize character. Most conventional novels that seek to capture a whole society use characters to stand for entire social groups—the dissipated aristocrat, the honest laborer—but this one goes to some trouble to stress that characters are less important because they are exemplary or synecdochical than because they play crucial roles in social, economic, and institutional networks. For example, Jo first appears in *Bleak House* not because he is a typical abandoned child forced to work on the streets, but because he is a point of contact between a dead man and the law. That is, the novel introduces us to Jo for the first time at the inquest into Nemo's death, and he is called to testify because a witness claims he is the only person Nemo has been seen talking to. Jo then reappears in the text, over and over, not because he represents poverty or childhood or social marginality, but because his literal location in the city at specific times and places makes him relevant to a murder investigation, efforts at urban reform, and even the institution of marriage. Jo's appearance in the novel is an effect of his role as a node in multiple networks.

By organizing the narrative around networks rather than persons, *Bleak House* does for character something like what Marx did for commodities: casting narrative persons less as powerful or symbolic agents in their own right than as moments in which complex and invisible social forces cross. Network form therefore prompts a rethinking of novelistic character. For example, caught up in the passage of contagion, legal inquiry, and urban space, Jo is shocked by his own apparent importance on the one hand and his total insignificance on the other. How can he be both entirely neglected by the social world and yet also unable to escape the webs of interconnection that necessarily link him to that world?

Network theorists argue that in most networks there are some nodes—hubs—that are more highly linked than others; while most nodes cluster together around shared functions and purposes, a few important nodes are simultaneously part of many large clusters. It is not hard to identify the hubs in *Bleak House*: Jo, Esther, Woodcourt, Tulkinghorn, Bucket, and Miss Flite all appear in multiple clusters and provide links between clusters. But again, this is a surprising and strangely incoherent list. It names not only central and powerful figures, for those who are the sites of the most

substantial traffic are not necessarily sources of either agency or authority. Some are simply proximate—in the right place at the right time—while others become unconscious bearers of connectability—disease or a secret love affair. Thus it is no accident that hubs are not necessarily centers of power: as the example of Jo makes clear, it is perfectly possible to function as a highly trafficked point of social intersection without having any control over the social oneself.

While the network invites Dickens to expand the usual affordances of narrative, narrative allows him to offer a shrewd understanding of networks. In this chapter, I have already touched on a few examples of the ways in which temporal rhythms collide with and reshape network arrangements—temporal delays in print and post, the addition of new nodes to the family, and the constant threat that multinational corporations will shift to newly favorable sites. By making use of a formal feature of the Victorian novel that has not often been theorized—sheer length³³—Dickens puts an especially loose and baggy narrative form to use to theorize networks in canny and persuasive ways.

The length of *Bleak House* affords some insight into networks that is precluded by shorter narrative forms, including the spate of recent “network narrative” films that struggle to represent globalized networks of politics, economics, and technology. These films, such as *Traffic* (2000), *Syriana* (2005), and *Babel* (2006), all rely on what network theorists call *chain networks*, where one event prompts another in a sequence of effects—more like dominoes than like the Internet. *Babel* might look like an exception at first, but it pretends to be more complex than it is by telling three of its four main stories as if they were simultaneous, when they are in fact sequential: reordering the plot gives you quite a straightforward cause-and-effect narrative. *Bleak House*, by contrast, relies on the more complex model of distributed networks, where the links between nodes arise in any order—anyone can run into almost anyone else on the streets of London—and this complicates and multiplies not only possibilities for causal relationships but for social relationships altogether, including unlikely ties between members of apparently far-flung social groups. After all, any number of distributed networks, from gossip to disease to urban space, can end up linking someone like Jo the lowly crossing sweeper to someone as remote as the haughty Sir Leicester Dedlock. The films, much simpler in plot because of their restricted length, all rely on a single principle of interconnection, like the drug trade or the oil industry, to undergird their plots, whereas Dickens layers on multiple principles of interconnection, linking the same individuals over and over again through different channels.

In the process, *Bleak House* offers a better formal understanding of one particular network—the family—than do Hollywood’s network narratives. *Traffic*, *Syriana*, and *Babel* all imagine the breakup of the family as the worst kind of violence wrought by networks. The restoration of the safety and integrity of the family becomes both the primary catalyst for plotted action and the primary source of thematic meaning. Formally speaking, the family emerges in these films as a singular unit, a whole, which can be threatened by networks. By contrast, consider the biggest secret in *Bleak House*—the link between Esther and her mother: this is the secret of an intimate, family relationship. But it does not begin as such in the novel’s telling: Esther and Lady Dedlock first appear as two distant points, only gradually brought together as linked nodes in the consciousness of both readers and characters. By beginning with a social and geographical gap between two people who are ignorant of one another’s existence, Dickens exposes not so much the splitting apart of families *by* networks but families *as networks*, in which the nodes are not always already fused together, but rather connected by paths that can be interrupted and stretched by other forms. *Bleak House* refuses to unify the family, then, and instead conceives of it as one of many networks, taking its place alongside the law, philanthropy, class hierarchy, and disease. In the process, the novel asks us not only to rethink character, but also relation, breaking apart even intimate ties to reveal them as networked forms.

Dickens then skillfully takes this analysis of the family a step farther, using narrative form to work through the dynamic unfolding of kinship networks over time. Consider one of the novel’s minor characters, Mrs. Badger, who is absurdly proud of having had three distinguished husbands: the first a naval captain, the second a professor “of European reputation,” and the third a surgeon. What Mrs. Badger makes clear is that a husband is not first and foremost a particular person but a position in a kinship network, and specifically a *replaceable* node. “Replaceable” also describes Esther’s two husbands, one of whom replaces himself and his house with another husband and another house in one of the most unsettling moments in the text.

Dickens’s interest in replaceability allows us to understand exactly how he brings narrative and network together. As anyone who has ever tried to make a genealogical chart will know, the family is never graspable as a whole. It stretches indefinitely across time and space. Distant branches connect ever outward, as marriage creates links to other families, old generations stretch back into the past indefinitely, and generations yet to come will continue to add nodes. And as Mrs. Badger suggests, the nodes of the family network are best figured as positions that can be endlessly emptied and refilled: new people supplant previous husbands and wives, sons and

daughters, sisters, cousins, grandparents. In short, the nodes repeatedly replace themselves, and in so doing replicate the network in ways that stretch the institution of the family itself across time. Or to put this another way: the temporal unfurling of networks cannot be “turned into space” without distorting our understanding of the form in some crucial ways. Engaged in a constant process of self-renewal, the networked form of kinship is never whole, but always emerging, perpetually in process.

The narrative form best suited to conveying this resistance to totality, I want to suggest, is plotted suspense. At first glance, these two impulses—the sprawling, ever-emerging and overlapping network, and the teleological drive of suspenseful narrative—might seem starkly opposed. Most classic readings of detective fiction suggest that endings are deferred in order to provide the eventual satisfactions of understanding and order. This is quite the reverse of the network, which is happy to lose us in its constantly criss-crossing maze. But conventional readings of detective fiction have missed the importance of the narrative middle by too strongly favoring the analysis of closure.³⁴ The suspense of the middle occurs when a narrative clearly signals that it is holding something back. Such moments might indicate that we are missing a crucial piece of information—like a secret—or they might deliberately prolong an uncertain process, holding off the outcome—a chase, a threat, a flirtation.

Bleak House offers multiple sources of suspense—family secrets, a mysterious murder, a baffling lawsuit, and a frantic midnight pursuit—and so insists that we spend hours and hours in the experience of uncertainty, the experience specifically of *withheld* knowledge. At any given moment, we know that we cannot grasp crucial pathways between nodes, and this points us to our more generalized ignorance of networks. We cannot ever apprehend the totality of the networks that organize us.

This is a formal fact of networks. Because these sprawling, overlapping, and indefinitely expanding processes of interconnectedness, from law to disease to kinship, can never be fully grasped all at once, the emphasis on withholding knowledge may actually be essential to the task of representing multiple distributed networks. Or to put this another way: in order to represent a world of networks, the text must refuse totality. *Bleak House* uses the suspense of its long middle to demonstrate that at any moment our knowledge of social interconnections can only be partial: we may intuit the overwhelmingly complex webs of social interconnections in glimpses and hints, but the networks that connect rich and poor, city and world, the dead and the living, are never fully present to consciousness. Since the overlapping of social networks approaches a magnitude and a complexity

so great that their wholeness defies full knowledge, Dickens opts for a narrative form that suggests and withholds—that is, the narrative of suspense.

By repeatedly offering and also suspending a knowledge of the networked social world, he hints that his novel is not—and indeed could never be—complete or encompassing. In any network, nodes can be replaced, and they can gather links to new nodes. To capture a moment, one must struggle to grasp the multiple systems of interconnection—constantly unfolding and expanding and overlapping—that constitute local instantiations of the social. Since these different systems emerge, expand, and develop in different times and places and at different rates, any apprehension of a cultural network must be responsive not only to multiple networks but also to their multiple temporalities. Thus *Bleak House* suggests that any historically particular event or institution or person is to be found at the crossing of numerous networks. The novel's massive scale might be necessary to the evocation of multiple distributed networks, but it still cannot really capture the social as a single, overarching meta-network, since so many of the networks Dickens describes extend beyond any temporal or spatial boundaries that one might try to set for them.

Bleak House, by organizing itself around such uncontainable networks, constantly runs up against the limits of its own capacity for representation. As Henry James put it so famously in the preface to *Roderick Hudson*, “Really, universally, relations stop nowhere.”³⁵ Yet Dickens refuses to be a Jamesian artist, choosing “eternally but to draw, by a geometry of his own, the circle within which [relations] shall happily *appear* to [stop]” (vii). Instead, *Bleak House* gestures to the very fact that relations constantly break the boundaries of representation. Far from claiming to capture the family, the city, or the nation, Dickens points us instead to a model of social interconnection that is larger and longer than even this dauntingly expansive novel itself could manage. Again and again, the networked plot hints at immeasurable durations and extensions that lie beyond its own considerable reach. The vastness of *Bleak House* affords not individual agency, not the primacy of families, and not the wholeness of the nation, but a kind of narratively networked sublime.

And what is perhaps most strange and compelling, in the end, is that this sublime complexity captures something all too ordinary at work. All of us, along with other species and objects, are located at the crossings of multiple unfolding networks that are perpetually linking bodies, ideas, and things through numerous channels at different rates and across different kinds of spaces. As they pattern relationships, networks—social, economic, electronic, ecological, viral, bacterial, legal, familial, national,

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and transnational—also run up against other forms, including territorial boundaries, which they sometimes cross and which at other times bring them to a halt. We may have become accustomed to thinking about communications, transportation, and economic networks as powerful connectors that consolidate nations or enable globalization, but a formalist approach reveals many opportunities, large and small, to hamper networks and their coordinating power. The bounded shape of the nation-state can work both with and against capital flow. Multiple communications networks can disrupt as well as unite a nation. And minor forms can sometimes work against major ones—a local mail carrier can weaken a centralized network of imperial power by superimposing another, more local network, and a woman poet can retreat to the boundaries of her bedroom to block the encroachment of some very tiresome social networks in favor of a richer, more expansive world.

THE WIRE

Most accounts of social relationships in literary and cultural studies encourage us to focus our attention on the ways that a couple of formations intersect at any given moment: imperialism and the novel, for example, or the law and print culture. But what happens if we change the scale of our formal perspective and begin with many forms? Paying attention to numerous overlapping social forms may seem daunting, if not impossible, but if it is in fact true that forms very often find their organizing power compromised, rerouted, or deflected by their encounters with other forms, then a formalist cultural studies interested in how power works will need to take account of what happens when a great many social, political, natural, and aesthetic forms encounter one another. What would such a formalist cultural studies look like?

I am going to make the eccentric claim here that it could look something like David Simon's superb television series, *The Wire* (2002–2008). The method I have favored in this book entails not only analysis but also detailed description—a willingness to observe and follow the impact of different kinds of forms on one another—and *The Wire* is a rare exploration of the ways that social experience can be structured and also rendered radically unpredictable by the dense overlapping of large numbers of social forms. When the series began, it looked something like a conventional television cop drama, with a police force pitted against drug dealers, but it widened its emphasis with each season to take in new institutions: first unions, then city politics, then education, and finally the press. Though the focus shifted with the seasons, the series built intersections with earlier institutions rather than replacing them, probing the sites and moments where they overlap, influence one another, and collide.

There are numerous bounded wholes and enclosures in *The Wire*, including prison cells, foster homes, administrative offices, and “Hamsterdam,” a designated zone for legalized drugs. These take shape amid many conflicting and colliding social rhythms, from the testing of schoolchildren to the fast tempo of news stories and the slower movement of election cycles. Hierarchies matter here, too, of course. The series explores not only points of

contact between the uncannily parallel, highly bureaucratic organizations of police force and drug dealers, but also other bureaucracies, including the law, education, and politics. These major institutions are ordered and disordered by different structuring hierarchies—racial, administrative, and generational. Finally, networks are perhaps the most noteworthy of all of *The Wire*'s forms, as the name of the whole series suggests. There is the web of economic transactions, which links Barksdale drug money to downtown real estate and international terrorism. There are social networks organized by class, from the boys in the pit to political fundraisers. There is the space of the city, which brings characters like Jimmy McNulty and Stringer Bell into contact through the accident of sheer proximity. There is gossip, which cascades up and down the social ladder. There are small-scale social groups, including the boxing ring and the Narcotics Anonymous group, which often cross paths with the organized network of Baltimore churches. And there is kinship, from the Barksdale code of family loyalty to Wallace's grandmother down at the shore.

All of these are structured according to different organizing principles, which run up against one another in unexpected and often frustrating ways. But together they produce experience, and do so from childhood onward. *The Wire* makes clear that children at Tilghman Middle School do not begin outside of political forms and institutions and move into them as they mature; rather, we see how even before birth the patterns of family and school are already meeting and informing one another, and how both are rerouted and reshaped in encounters with electoral politics, drug trafficking, police administration, social services, and the law. Each child's story emerges out of a complex collision of social forms that can never be limited to one or two dominant social principles—race, economics, the city, the family, politics, the law, or education—but takes shape amid the pressures of all of these and their constantly colliding patterns. Thus *The Wire* allows us to ask what happens if we change the scale of our formal perspective to begin with an account not of two or three forms only—marriage and career, or meter and the state—but of vast numbers of social forms meeting one another.

There is something perverse, to be sure, in finding a theory of the social world not in science, not in philosophy, not in experience, but in fiction. *The Wire* may be realist in some ways, but it is obviously not the real: it is constructed and stylized, and it is hardly free of ideology or narrative artifice. And yet, to turn to *The Wire* as a theorization of the social is to be faithful to the roots of the word *theory*, which comes from the Greek word for "a looking at," "spectacle," or "contemplation." *Theoria* entails the possibility

that one might be able to extrapolate generalizable rules about the world from the experience of a spectacle, and here I am suggesting that there is in *The Wire* precisely this potential for theorizing the social.

Sociologists Anmol Chaddha and William Julius Wilson agree, pointing to the particular affordances of fiction that can elude conventional sociological scholarship, a field that acknowledges the power of multiple social forms but nonetheless tends to isolate one pattern at a time for analysis:

As a work of fiction, *The Wire* does not replace rigorous academic scholarship on the problems of urban inequality and poverty. But . . . the show demonstrates the interconnectedness of systemic urban inequality in a way that can be very difficult to illustrate in academic works. Due to the structure of academic research, scholarly works tend to focus on many of these issues in relative isolation. A number of excellent studies analyze the impacts of deindustrialization, crime and incarceration, and the education system on urban inequality. It is often implicitly understood among scholars that these are deeply intertwined, but an in-depth analysis of any one of these topics requires such focused attention that other important factors necessarily receive less discussion.¹

The Wire emerges as valuable here for its capacity to represent multiple forms operating at once, providing a serious analytical alternative to the usual scholarly attention to one or two forms at a time.

I will pay my closest attention in this chapter to a formal element of *The Wire* not always understood to lend itself to theory: its plot. Here I am following the lead of Fredric Jameson, who argues that in this series “plot construction . . . has a theoretical or philosophical dimension.”² And it is no accident that the particular plotting of this television drama should prompt a new respect for the powers of plot generally. Not unlike *Bleak House*, *The Wire* expands the usual affordances of its medium by intertwining over one hundred characters in multiple intricate sequences that overlap and reshape one another. It links apparently distant or disconnected characters, showing how a homeless heroin addict in Baltimore can have an impact on Russian drug smugglers and the governor of Maryland. And like *Bleak House*, but unlike almost any other fictional text, it dramatically expands the usual number of characters while also connecting them to each other through *multiple* channels. There is no single principle of interconnection that links each to every other. The sheer complexity and intricacy of *The Wire*’s plot are therefore truly striking—and indeed different from almost all conventional storylines.

Despite Jameson's recognition of the importance of plotted form here, his analysis of the series remains formally unconvincing. He argues that small moments in *The Wire*'s plot introduce "a slight rift or crack" into its "realism," which, according to Jameson, is all about "necessity": "why it had to happen like that and why reality is both the irresistible force and the unmovable obstacle." He contends that realist plots have certain, inexorable outcomes, while the plots of utopias open out unusual or unexpected possibilities. *The Wire* converts one into the other, Jameson argues, as "the Utopian future here and there breaks through, before reality and the present again close it down" (371–72). But he gives us no way to distinguish between these two kinds of plot: that is, what is it that makes one sequence of events necessary and another implausible and fantastic if both structure experience in the same text? How could one plot "break through" the other, if both are organizing elements of the same overarching narrative? Jameson himself distinguishes between them based on convention: some plotted arcs are familiar and recognizable and therefore realist; others, more unusual and surprising, are for him utopian.

But it is the genius of *The Wire* to show that *both* kinds of plot are plausible. The series presents all manner of outcomes looming at all times, imagining multiple possible paths immanent in every formal encounter, some conventional, others more surprising. I propose, then, to flip Jameson's argument upside down. Rather than seeing realism as closing down strange and unfamiliar plots, we can understand *The Wire* as making strange, unconventional plots plausible—realist. My own reading departs from Jameson's interest in genre to come much closer to that of sociologists like Wilson, who explains that *The Wire* "shows incredible imagination and understanding about the way the world works."³ Fiction it is, certainly—artful and stylized, without question. But in and through its plot it seeks to track the plausible unfolding of events as forms collide.

Plotting matters in particular to our capacity to think about causality. As I have said before, narrative is an ideal form for avoiding metaphysical truth-claims about causes: it presents causality in something of the same way that it actually appears to us in the world, through an experience of unfolding. And serialized television seems especially well suited for this, since, unlike many novels, no obtrusive omniscient narrator intervenes to tell us why something has happened, and since, like the novel but unlike conventional film, it has hours and hours and hours to unfold relationships. The narrative affords hundreds of social forms, tracking them as they cooperate, come into conflict, and overlap, without positing a single deep structure or original cause. And since forms can move across contexts, taking their own

range of affordances with them, the plot gives us a way to theorize the relations among forms that appear both inside and outside of fiction.

The Wire is famously bleak, and its critics—perhaps most notably Slavoj Žižek—have condemned it for its “fatalistic world view.”⁴ It might therefore seem politically ineffective, even counterproductive, to turn to David Simon’s series for a theory of social forms. Most outcomes for the characters are tragic or ironic, and no entirely restructured alternatives take shape. Sometimes characters mourn for the old days, suggesting a break between past and present. Both the unions and the newspapers have seen better times. But the series also ironizes such nostalgic sentiments. In one case, Bodie, a drug dealer who is no older than sixteen or seventeen, looks with regret at his eighth-grade lookouts who are off to play with pigeons: “Young ’uns don’t got a scrap of work ethic nowadays. If it wasn’t for us pops I wouldn’t even bother.”⁵ Similarly, Wee-Bay, who has killed many times, longs for the good old days under Avon Barksdale, before Marlo’s rise to power: “[W]e did that shit right; word was your bond; man looked out for his own, knowing he in a family. . . . But today, it’s all fucked up.”⁶ In a series that ends by suggesting that its young characters are about to replicate the lives of their predecessors—with Michael as the new Omar, and Duquon as the new Bubbles—the repetitiveness of patterns seems to triumph over attempts to generate genuine difference. Or to put this another way: although the world of Baltimore may have changed over time, *The Wire* focuses our attention on institutional rhythms of replication and substitution that stretch forward and backward in time rather than on moments of dramatic change or rupture.

But it would also be a mistake to claim that *The Wire* gives us no way to think social relations outside of a too-abstract capitalism or tragic fate, which decrees that all is predetermined. To the contrary, we are repeatedly, even insistently, shown how things work, with openings to multiple alternatives at every turn. And how things work is relentlessly a matter of form. Patterns and arrangements structure experience in such complicated ways that they often derail happy endings, but at the same time they do not altogether foreclose the possibility of events turning out otherwise. Indeed, *The Wire* repeatedly imagines the ways that forms might work together for genuine social change. If those get disrupted, the source cannot always be traced back to a single structure of power—economics, politics, or race—but rather to the overlapping of multiple forms.

I will consider forms in *The Wire* in the same order that I have used to structure this book as a whole: bounded wholes, rhythms, hierarchies, and networks. This order is arbitrary in the sense that none of these is primary

or basic: each can be nested inside the other—wholes can contain rhythms and hierarchies networks. In fact, *The Wire* helps us to see how interdependent these forms must always be. But for the sake of intelligibility, I want to build my case by focusing on one at a time, and only then exploring their interdependence. My reading will focus almost exclusively on the arc of the series' interconnected plots, since it is my contention that *The Wire*—though notable for its rich characterization, its excellent acting, its refusal of simple stereotypes, and even its soundtrack—is truly exceptional in its attention to the ways that multiple social forms unfold in relation to one another, their encounters producing serious, painful, and occasionally promising effects.

Whole

Many bounded wholes organize experience in *The Wire*. Most of these are literal spatial enclosures, from homes, offices, and city limits to shipping containers, public meeting spaces, bars, stash houses, and prison cells. Like the unified wholes we encountered earlier, all of these have boundaries that distinguish inside from outside; all afford protection or imprisonment, inclusion and exclusion. Drug dealers fight over the limits of their turf, and police identify strongly with either Eastern or Western districts. I will begin here by focusing briefly on three different examples of encounters between spatial containers, as illustrative—rather than exhaustive—of *The Wire*'s interest in the power of various contending and colliding enclosures to organize and disorganize experience.

Perhaps the most notable example of the power of bounded enclosures appears as an experiment in season 3, when Bunny Colvin creates *Hamsterdam*, a strictly bounded trio of urban zones where drug dealers and users can behave as they wish, safe from police interference. These enclosed spaces take the drug trade off the usual street corners, distributed throughout poor neighborhoods in the city, and allow public health groups, who now have easy, centralized access to addicts, to begin to distribute condoms and offer needle exchanges and rehabilitation programs. *Hamsterdam* then has consequences for other enclosures, both small and large. First of all, neighborhood boys, once hired by drug dealers to stand on the corners and act as lookouts, now have nothing to do and so drift into a different kind of contained space, Dennis "Cutty" Wise's community-run boxing ring. Second, Mayor Clarence Royce is momentarily impressed by the success of the zones, and his delay in shutting them down helps to bring about his defeat in the next election, catapulting Tommy Carcetti into leadership of the city and eventually the state. Where one might expect the leader of

the larger, official political space—the city—to define the smaller, experimental one—Hamsterdam—in fact the mere existence of the free zones shifts power relations in Baltimore and eventually Maryland as a whole, suggesting that minor forms have consequences for major ones. These three defined spaces, each a container with clear boundaries, one nested within the next—Hamsterdam, Baltimore, and Maryland—are formally similar, but that does not mean that they are coordinated to the same political or organizational ends.

In season 2, the relation of enclosures again suggests that the smallest containers can affect the largest scales of political power. At the start, police commander Stan Valchek is furious that Frank Sobotka of the dockworker's union has bested him in a small-time quarrel over who gets to install a new stained-glass window in a local church. Seeking to win a power struggle over a single parish church, Valchek calls in favors at the Baltimore police department to launch an investigation into Sobotka's finances. Sobotka turns out to be taking money from an international smuggling ring, and the police department and soon the FBI turn their attention to larger targets than the Baltimore-based union boss. Valchek has called in both Baltimore and federal law enforcement to prevail in a neighborhood fight, only to find that the city, national law enforcement, and transnational networks have their own logics, which unfold well beyond his control. The politics of a single church triggers the sequence that ensues, but as the parish overlaps with other jurisdictions—the city police, the national FBI, and global trade and terror agents—major forms end up engulfing minor ones.

In my third example, we see how bounded shapes can collide to trigger a far-reaching sequence of events. When the Barksdale solidier, Wee-Bay Brice, willingly accepts a life sentence for the sake of the organization, he is enclosed for life in a prison. In exchange, the Barksdales support and protect Wee-Bay's girlfriend De'Londa and their son Namond in an expensively furnished home. But the Barksdale drug crew is soon driven off their territory by Marlo's ruthless new team of dealers. Having lost their turf, the Barksdales say that they can no longer pay for Wee-Bay's home. De'Londa responds by sending Namond into the streets to sell drugs, where he is driven off his own corner territory by rivals, fails in the business, and as punishment is thrown out of his mother's home. Thanks to an academic experiment happening in Namond's school, where children who are especially troublesome are enclosed in a separate classroom, the boy comes to the attention of former police officer Bunny Colvin, forced into retirement because of his own experiments with bounded wholes. Bunny offers Namond temporary sanctuary and eventually a new home. Here, then, each bounded

space has an impact on the next. An enclosed prison cell is exchanged for a protected home, which is endangered when drug-turf boundaries are breached, which causes Namond to be ejected from his home. But Namond is also one of the few characters who has a happy ending in the series, and he succeeds because the school's reorganization of space happens to propel him into two new protected enclosures, Bunny's classroom and his adoptive home: without those, his fate would be like that of his homeless peers, Randy and Duquon. No single form dominates or causes this sequence of events: not the home, not the school, not the drug territory, not the prison cell. But all of these enclosures play a part in the organization of Namond's story, which is literally unthinkable without them.

Rhythm

The Wire is as interested in the collision of social rhythms and tempos as it is in the overlap of bounded spaces, offering up an impossibly complex assemblage of temporalities. The plot layers routine police assessments of crime statistics on top of biennial political campaigns on top of annual school testing on top of the daily deadlines of newspapers. Narratively speaking, it is often impossible to determine whether the events represented are sequential or simultaneous: *fabula* can be hard to deduce from *sjuzhet*. To be sure, as it constantly cuts back and forth between plots and between institutions—moving rapidly from the newsroom to the classroom to the mayor's office to the home to the street-corner—each particular episode does imply a temporal unfolding. We tend to see shots that take place in the morning, followed by those during the day, evening, and then night. But are the morning scenes taking place at the same time, or consecutively? Similarly, seasons change, but we rarely have a sense of precise dates, or of the spans of time that pass between episodes. The series seems to resist temporal exactness, preferring to capture a feeling of simultaneous recurrence, patterns of repetition all going on at once, rather than events following each other in any precise order.

As the plot unfolds, we see how each institution has its own temporal rhythms, and often multiple rhythms, overlaid one on the other. Mrs. Sampson, a teacher at Tilghman Middle School, describes one school tempo: "You can tell the days by [the kids'] faces. The best day is Wednesday. That's the farthest they get from home, from whatever's going on in the streets. You see smiles, then. Monday is angry. Tuesdays they're caught between Monday and Wednesday, so it could go either way. Thursdays, they're feeling that weekend coming. Friday is bad again."⁷ The school is also organized

temporally by grade level. One of the most painful moments in *The Wire* is Duquon's graduation from middle school. Part of a beleaguered school system's attempt to show that its students are advancing academically, Duquon is suddenly expected to move forward to the ninth grade at mid-year. This interrupts the widespread practice of routine social promotion—which moves children forward with their peers by age, rather than academic level—and it will prove catastrophic for Duquon. He is not ready for the socially mature world of high school and so drops out altogether, only to learn that there are no good alternatives. He is not yet old enough to find paid work in a legitimate business, and so, cast out of the bounds of home, his middle-school cohort, and the workplace, both too old and too young, he faces a bleak future of drug addiction and homelessness. This is the formal power of temporal organization both at its most mundane—Duquon's promotion is, after all, just a routine bureaucratic action—and at its most tragic.

The Wire often represents characters caught between social tempos, surprised by the effects of multiple rhythms colliding. In one example, Lester Freamon and Kima Greggs, having tracked drug dealers' donations to high-ranking political officials, decide to take advantage of the primary election to hand out subpoenas, reasoning that the election cycle will make people pay attention to them. And pay attention they do. Kima is kicked out of Major Crimes, and finds herself on the bottom rung of the ladder, a novice, in Homicide. When the mayor fears that a scandal will erupt around the murder of a state's witness, he puts pressure on Police Commissioner Burrell to slow down the investigation, so Burrell puts Kima—the inexperienced rookie—on the case. The press gets hold of the story, interviewing candidate Tony Gray who takes advantage of the situation to humiliate Kima, showing her up as a naive know-nothing. "What the fuck I ever do to him?" she asks.⁸ But to see this as an interpersonal drama is a mistake; it is actually a case of colliding temporal forms. Kima has been caught at the junction of contending tempos that include the pace of two different police investigations, the timing of a mayoral primary, her own newness at the job, and the daily news cycle.

Kima is not the only worker on *The Wire* to turn over—to be replaced and to replace others. Some of the most powerful temporal forms in the series are patterns of surrogation. As soon as characters die, get fired, or go to jail, others replace them—in the police bureaucracy, the drug trade, and even the family. The police in *The Wire* complain that death and jail can never put an end to the drug trade, because the dealers are endlessly replaced; this means that their own jobs will never be done; so they too are

endlessly replaceable. *The Wire* also makes it clear that these surrogations are not limited to official organizations. In season 3, we see McNulty at a baseball game: his ex-wife Elana has taken up with a new man, a wealthy downtown lawyer, whose seats are far better than his own, much to his sons' disappointment when they switch from maternal to paternal custody. This scene suggests that the realm of private, intimate relationships is hardly safe from institutionalized patterns of turnover. Indeed, we might think of the many foster and adoptive parents in the series, including the four substitute fathers in season 4—Colvin, Carver, Prez, and Bubbles—each of whom considers taking on a kind of parental role in relation to one of the boys—Namond, Randy, Duquon, and Sherrod. The family clearly involves its own processes of surrogation.

The series thus shows how all of the major institutions it represents endure across time. There are no dramatic historical breaks on *The Wire* precisely because the many institutions that impose order on experience—family, school, government, business—operate by way of iterable patterns of surrogation and replacement. This is not the same as fatalism or stasis: institutions can introduce a new pattern of student promotion, decline over time through lost business, or shift workers to new positions. We can see the repercussions of these changes as new forms encounter other forms both inside and outside of a particular institution, but it is a crucial aspect of social rhythm that institutions replicate themselves across time through repetition and substitution.

Hierarchy

One of the most powerful institutional forms that endure through patterns of replaceability in *The Wire* is the vertical form of the hierarchy, which crops up everywhere, from racism to the bureaucratic hierarchies of the police force, political campaign, and, most startlingly, drug organizations. Part of what makes *The Wire* so brilliant is its revelation that the bureaucratic forms of modern institutions are so pervasive that they have come to organize not only official institutions but underworld activity as well.⁹ The business of drugs turns out to produce the same kinds of pecking orders, promotions and demotions, incentives for good work, quality assessments, and business mergers as the routines of official institutions. Stringer Bell's borrowing of *Robert's Rules of Order* for his cross-Baltimore drug consortium is perhaps the most elegant instance of the pervasive spread of bureaucratic forms. And what this means is that the most powerful institutions portrayed on *The Wire*—not only the police force and the drug trade, but

city politics, the school system, and the newspaper—are, without exception, structured according to remarkably similar hierarchical forms. The choices made by *The Wire*'s characters—from police lieutenants to mid-level drug dealers, from city council members to kids in the boxing ring—are, in most cases, strategic attempts to retain their positions or to reach up the ladder to occupy a higher rank. Just about everyone can report to a superior, snitch on a peer, or be demoted. *The Wire* draws our attention, over and over, to the hierarchical structuring of experience.

Season 3, for example, opens with police detectives planning to arrest a mid-level dealer. They expect him to be replaced with a garrulous underling whose chatter, they hope, will give the whole game away. “What makes you think they’ll promote the wrong man?” asks the police commissioner. “We do it all the time,” Daniels responds. Burrell laughs, but it is worth noting that he also uses this point to turn the conversation to the question of Daniels’s own promotion, telling him that his wife’s run for office—to replace the mayor’s ally—is prompting the mayor to hold up Daniels’s career move.¹⁰ Each of the persons in question—Drac, Marla Daniels, Cedric Daniels—has the potential to take the position of another in a hierarchy, just as Burrell and the mayor are trying to hold on to their own high-ranking spots. All are vulnerable, and no place in any of these pecking orders will remain empty for long.

Importantly, however, even the bureaucratic hierarchy does not emerge in *The Wire* as a single source of clear power. Bureaucratic institutions turn out to be neither monolithic panoptic nor simply hierarchical structures—as we might expect—but rather complex and uneven overlappings of norms and practices that work against each other as often as they work together. A crucial part of the plotted tension of season 1, for instance, revolves around the question of whether Lieutenant Daniels will seek his own promotion, pleasing his bosses at the expense of the drug case, or whether he will choose to value his detectives’ work, pursuing the investigation and risking his career. The outcome feels genuinely uncertain. And crucially, we come to learn that it is not just Daniels’s choice that is involved here: Carver, his underling, is secretly reporting all of his lieutenant’s choices to the Deputy of Operations, thereby securing his own promotion while undermining both the success of the case and the choices of his own immediate superior. Meanwhile, McNulty is constantly challenging Daniels’s authority by investigating the case in his own way, typically dragging his partner Bunk Moreland into the process by invoking the value of the peer partnership over the chain of command. None of these characters chooses

to work outside of the bureaucracy altogether: rather, each favors one aspect of bureaucratic organization over others. In the process, they come into conflict in ways that are enabled by precisely the bureaucratic forms that also frustrate them. Thus the text refuses the narrative logic of personal intentions as well as the logic of monolithic institutional power, opting instead for the intricate interweaving of competing bureaucratic forms—multiple hierarchies and alliances—as they organize, constrain, and overwhelm individual ends.

Unpredictable consequences ensue when multiple vertical forms meet in *The Wire*. Marla and Cedric Daniels separate when he refuses to pursue an ambitious rise up the career ladder, and she pursues her own political ambitions instead, running for city council. Daniels agrees to support her, only to find his own career further damaged by his wife's decision to run against one of the mayor's close political allies. But when the mayor, under pressure from the Hamsterdam debacle, is forced to switch allegiances, he lends his support to Marla Daniels and gives Cedric a career boost. This eventually changes the career trajectory of Bill Rawls, whose sole and ruthless aim is to rise in the bureaucracy of the police department. Rawls is horrified to discover that Cedric Daniels may be promoted over his head because the white mayor, Tommy Carcetti, needs an African-American police commissioner to solidify support for his administration. The majority black Baltimore population, he is told, will not stand for a white commissioner working for a white mayor. "It's funny how it works out," Daniels says. "All those years I'm trying to climb the ladder, kissing ass, covering ass, doing what I'm told. I finally let some of it out, say what I really think, and I'm going from lieutenant to colonel in little more than a year."¹¹ This unpredictability has been the effect of a formal collision: the hierarchies of gender, race, and bureaucracy. The gendered hierarchy of the Daniels marriage—where the wife serves the husband's career—runs into trouble when the husband's place in the police bureaucracy stagnates. The wife takes her husband's failure as a reason to pursue her own rise, only to find herself, thanks to political matters beyond her knowledge and control, propelling her former husband far beyond anything either of them had ever expected. Meanwhile, Rawls, who has been single-mindedly dedicated to climbing the career ladder, finds that the hierarchy of race—here inverted from the norm in majority black Baltimore—allows him to be outstripped by the much less ambitious Daniels. In the final montage, we see the conventional hierarchies of race and career ambition restored, as Daniels's refusal to manipulate crime statistics thrusts him out of the police force altogether, and Rawls is rewarded for

loyalty to Carcetti by being named state commissioner. But we do not see the links in the chain that produce this conventional ending. Instead, *The Wire* has shown, closely and carefully, how effectively hierarchies can throw one another into disarray.¹²

Network

We have seen how bounded wholes, rhythms, and hierarchies produce tangled and unexpected effects in *The Wire*'s Baltimore. But what is it that connects all the pieces, joins all the participants, creates the larger plot structure? This brings us to our last form: the network. Several critics have argued that the real protagonist of the show is the city of Baltimore, which is portrayed as an overlapping set of networks, each operating according to its own principles of interconnection. Others have said that the real agent is capitalism. "Follow the money," says Lester Freamon, tracking economic links from nodes in the Barksdale drug business to downtown real estate and electoral politics. Information, too, has power, and it too moves along network paths: phone calls among drug dealers prompt the detectives' desire for wiretapping technology to reveal the structure of the drug business, and gossip and informants provide crucial hinges between police and drug dealers when the wiretap fails. There are other networks that exert power here: official, institutional networks, such as the legal system, which brings together police officers, judges, lawyers, prison guards, witnesses, convicts, and informants; and illegal networks, including the consortium of drug dealers organized by Stringer Bell, which links up East and West Baltimore, and has connections to unions, politicians, corner kids, Russian prostitutes, and global smugglers. This final example points to the impossibility of thoroughly disconnecting different networks: the drug trade must overlap with other economic transactions and run up against the legal system, while taking place on city streets and drawing on ties of kinship. And yet, while there is no question that these networks overlap and link together, they also follow discrete principles of interconnection: kinship is not the same as the city streets and will never be, but both provide crucial connections. The multiple networks that tie the city together—trade, the legal system, and the circulation of information, among others—often reach beyond its boundaries, so that the shape of the city fails to contain its many networks.

Networks on *The Wire* link other social forms, including enclosures (connecting the school to the prison cell, for instance) and hierarchies (as when drug dealing kingpins contribute to the campaign war chests of ambitious politicians). They also link temporal patterns: as the detectives investigate

links between drugs and politics during the election season, both police officers and politicians know that they can leak stories to a press always hungry for something juicy for the evening news cycle. Networks can have rhythms of their own (gossip can move fast; court cases can be slowed down by missing witnesses); and they can be organized hierarchically (as in the legal system or the drug trade). Networks thus not only connect but overlap with other forms.

Like bounded shapes, rhythms, and hierarchies, networks also collide with one another on *The Wire*. In one example, Bubbles, a former police informant, runs into Prez, a former police officer, at Tilghman Middle School. Crossing paths in the same enclosed space, Bubbles assumes that Prez is working as an undercover cop, but in fact the paths that link them this time are less obvious. Bubbles is there to try to educate his young business associate, Sherrod, who refuses to be contained by the school walls, while Prez has left the police force to teach eighth grade after mistakenly shooting a black cop and being publicly accused of racism. Cutty, too, crosses their paths at the school, having been hired as a seasonal truant enforcer through the recommendation of the Deacon, whose exceptionally expansive network reaches across politicians, school administrators, police officers, and the poor people of the west side. ("A good church man is always up in everybody's shit," as the Deacon himself puts it.¹³) The space of the school is thus crisscrossed by networks that gather together people who have been joined before by the network of law enforcement.

Consider, for another example, the fate of D'Angelo Barksdale, who is caught, at the end of season 1, between his position in the family and his potential to act as a hinge between the network of drug dealers and the courts. The family is a powerful structuring principle for Dee: the fact that he is Avon Barksdale's nephew means that he has often bypassed the usual business hierarchies and reaped special privileges. But Avon also requires that D'Angelo accept a twenty-year jail term for the sake of the family. After Dee has made up his mind to refuse the family, informing on the Barksdale crew to the police, and promising a huge career-clinching victory for those trying to prosecute Avon, his mother visits him in jail: "How the fuck you gonna start over without your peoples?" she asks.¹⁴ The outcome, at this moment, is very much in question. D'Angelo could plausibly go either way. Following a pause of powerful suspense, Dee yields to his mother, choosing the power of kinship networks over the safeguards of police protection.

The Wire favors those characters who understand the power of network forms. The police who do street rips, gathering up small-time dealers, never

get anywhere: it is only a knowledge of drug dealing hubs that will allow police work to progress. The most successful and sympathetic detectives, like Freamon, use the networking technology of the wiretap to uncover knowledge of the drug dealers' networks, as the drug kingpins themselves try to conceal the nodes that claim the most network centrality, and to expose only the least networked nodes. Stringer Bell grasps the value and power of linking East and West Baltimore drug rings, while Avon remains tied to habits of family and neighborhood loyalty. Omar's remarkable freedom and power comes not least from his knowledge of the major drug dealers' networks, which he gains by constant observation. Good journalists, we learn in season 5, always have robust networks that cross institutions, including the mayor's office and the police force. Even Bubbles, poor and marginal, is one of *The Wire*'s most beloved characters, one whose importance to the plot rests on his willingness to act as a hinge between networks of law enforcement and drug dealers.

Why is a knowledge of networks so crucial in *The Wire*? Since networks can always make one vulnerable—a schoolboy witness, willing to make the link between streets and police force, could take down a whole criminal operation—a knowledge of network links is absolutely crucial to maintaining or unsettling a fragile hold on power. But *The Wire* also suggests that knowledge of network links is essential to understanding the ways that the social world works. What makes things happen in Baltimore, *The Wire* suggests, is no single social group or form—not money or politics or race or the family or the social elite—but the many webs of small and subtle interconnections that can link a low-level cop to the mayor, via police bureaucracy, daily news cycles, and the classroom. To understand how Avon Barksdale is brought down or Carcetti propelled to power requires a careful tracing of the connecting links between forms both major and minor.

Every plot sequence in *The Wire* follows a networked logic, inviting us to track the surprisingly byzantine paths between social forms as they coordinate, transform, or block one another. Or to put this another way: one cannot understand “the social” outside of the many intricate and open-ended plots depicted by *The Wire*. Any attempt to isolate the power of education or poverty or drugs will be doomed to failure, since the crucial fact is that none of these work in isolation. *The Wire* imagines that the process of capturing social experience will not lie in stories that follow a sequence of separate institutional forms—one narrative about a hospital, another about lawyers, a third about a school—but through attention to the many points where forms collide.

Knowing Forms

The Wire's plot appears so complex that it often seems to thwart both knowledge and action. The characters themselves, though often highly mindful of hierarchies, are largely unaware of other formal overlaps and collisions. This ignorance can lead to tragedy, as for example when Assistant Principal Marcia Donnelley tries to separate the bounded spaces of home and school definitively, warning Prez away from seeing Duquon as his own child:

You and your wife, you don't have children, do you? . . . Well, have some. For better or for worse, they're yours for life. The kids in this school aren't yours. You do your piece with them, and you let them go. Because there'll be plenty more coming up behind Duquon, and they're gonna need your help too.¹⁵

For Donnelly, the teacher's children belong in the middle-class home, whereas the children in the school are endlessly replaceable, interchangeable units in a perpetual process of institutional turnover. But Donnelly turns out to be wrong: it is soon after this scene that Bunny Colvin will successfully cross the divide between home and school, working out a deal with Wee-Bay to take Namond into his own family. He substitutes himself as father in the kinship network, while he moves Namond between the enclosures of school and home. It is intriguing, too, that he manages to convince Wee-Bay to be replaced by pointing to him out that Namond will now be able to slot himself into a place in the social hierarchy that would never have been open to him if Wee-Bay had remained his father. Namond now can climb the social ladder thanks to his new home, while Duquon, thanks to Mrs. Donnelly's logic of strict separation of shapes, remains one of many interchangeable units of black poverty and neglect.

Another tragic example of what can happen when no one is conscious of the collision of forms, is the story of Randy Wagstaff, who has been acting as a lookout for a sexual encounter in the middle school. Caught, he is terrified that his foster mother will throw him out of her house and he will end up in a group home, so he confesses to the assistant principal that he knows about a murder. Three forms help to govern Randy's fate—the boys' bathroom, his foster home, and the group home—all of which are bounded spaces that have the capacity to exclude as well as include, to imprison as well as protect. His fear of being shifted from one enclosure to another to

another prompts him to divulge crucial knowledge of a crime, and so involves the police department. There, Ellis Carver, who has offered to act as the boy's foster father but is stymied by social services, passes Randy on to Herc, who is eager to get himself out of trouble with his superiors, hoping that information from Randy will allow him to climb the career ladder by delivering up drug kingpin Marlo Stanfield. Herc decides that Randy cannot help him rise, and casually leaks the information that Randy is a snitch to one of Marlo's people, who immediately reports this fact to his superiors. Randy emerges as a threatening hinge with the potential to link the police to the drug dealer's network. Marlo destroys the boy's home and foster mother, and Randy finds himself in precisely the group home he has most desperately wanted to avoid. Caught among at least three bounded wholes and three hierarchies—the school administration, the police bureaucracy, and the drug trade—Randy ends up trapped and brutalized in a home that is all too much like a prison.

Both characters and critics bewail the power of what they call “the system” portrayed on *The Wire*, but it is crucial to note that “the system” is less an organized or integrated single structure than it is precisely this heaped assortment of wholes, rhythms, hierarchies, and networks.¹⁶ The police administration fails because it depends on a simple model of individual responsibility—guilt and innocence that can be known through the arrest and prosecution of small-time drug deals on street corners but does not begin to grasp the crisscrossing forms that produce social experience. On the other hand, large-scale, abstract theories of capitalism fail too. Patrick Jagoda argues that *The Wire* insists on a particular kind of “distributed thought” suitable to networks rather than “a grand theory of capitalism”:

Theories of a seamless social totality too easily produce stability out of dynamic processes. *The Wire*, however, teems with contradictions and instabilities. The series carefully attends to the controversies, contradictions, and messy complexities of American social life. The connections that make up social networks, after all, are rarely smooth and continuous. Every political ecology—every socially embedded system of accumulation—is a precarious, tottering structure.¹⁷

Jagoda's invocation of a complex “political ecology” here is powerful, and I think he is right to see *The Wire* as demanding a specific kind of “distributed thought.” But it is important to recall, too, that the series also reaches well beyond the network form alone as a way of understanding the social.

By shifting its focus from the power of individuals or elite groups to the intricate “political ecology” of a whole world of contending forms, *The Wire* allows us to see networks as linking other forms, but also derailing them and being derailed by them.

Along the way, the series, like *Bleak House*, offers an unconventional account of agency. Individual characters do have some power to make choices—D’Angelo can choose to snitch on the Barksdales, Stringer Bell can opt for the warrior ethic or the business model he has adopted from corporate practice, and Tommy Carcetti can choose between the schools’ budget shortfall and the collapse of police morale—but these examples all suggest that individual decisions matter only within environments of colliding forms where no individual or elite group controls either procedures or outcomes. It is not just that small players like Dee cannot dictate their own fates: no one—including the mayor and the police commissioner—can predict what will happen or exert a clear control over outcomes. Indeed, as new characters replace old ones in positions of power and authority, they typically find themselves becoming like their predecessors, against their best intentions. This is true of Carcetti when he replaces Royce, but it is also true of McNulty in season 5, when he has a brief stint as a supervisor and finds himself acting strangely like the supervisors he has so loved to resist in the past. While it is certainly the case that some characters have positions of high status or belong to powerful elites, then, it does not follow that their intentions wholly determine events. And if characters have limited agency, what limits them are precisely preexisting social forms: bureaucratic hierarchies that are themselves shaped by electorates organized by race; bounded spaces that include drug territories, prison cells, city limits, and group homes; and social tempos that constantly overlap, from budget cycles and school calendars to election campaigns and court cases. Far from an ideologically coherent society with power lodged in the hands of a few, *The Wire* gives us a social world constantly unsettled by the bewildering and unexpected effects of clashes among wholes, rhythms, hierarchies, and networks.

The few characters who recognize the power and significance of multiple forms—Lester Freamon, Bunny Colvin, and Omar Little—all make strategic decisions which, temporarily at least, permit outcomes that frustrate or elude the conventional distribution of power. Freamon manages to link politicians to drug smugglers by following the tracks of economic and information networks, briefly exposing a corrupt elite. Colvin reshapes the city and the world of the corner boys into new bounded wholes until he is brought down by the mayor, and he succeeds in offering one of those

boys a safe home and promising future. Omar remains comparatively free, the consummate outsider, refusing to join hierarchies and always escaping from enclosing shapes. But he works the network all the same, showing us that he understands well how both hierarchies and networks operate. All of these are sympathetic, even heroic. They are the show's epistemological and ethical exemplars, and they perform a reading of the social that is nothing other than a canny formalism.